PAHLÉ INDIA FOUNDATION
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ENHANCING FEMALE ENTREPRENEURSHIP & EMPLOYMENT
in the MSME Sector

A Gender-Intentional, Multi-State Perspective

September, 2025

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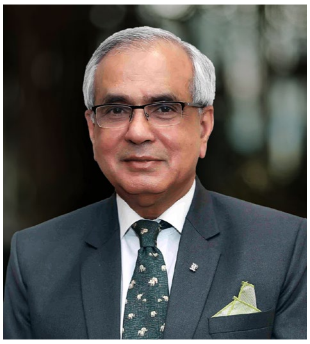
A Gender-Intentional, Multi-State Perspective

Letter from the Chairperson, Pahlé India Foundation



Dr. Rajiv Kumar
Chairperson
Pahlé India Foundation

It gives me great pleasure to present this report by my colleagues at Pahlé India Foundation (PIF), titled Enhancing Female Entrepreneurship and Employment in the MSME Sector: A Gender-Intentional, Multi-State Perspective.

This report addresses one of the most pressing gaps in our economic journey–the disproportionately low participation of women in India's Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSME) sector. Despite MSMEs being the backbone of our economy, creating over 20 crore jobs, only about 15 million of the 63 million MSMEs are owned by women. This imbalance not only restricts women's economic empowerment but also limits the sector's potential to drive India's aspiration of becoming a developed nation–Viksit Bharat–by 2047.

Through extensive stakeholder consultations across six states–Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, and Uttar Pradesh–and rigorous secondary research, this study identifies the challenges faced by women entrepreneurs and employees in the MSME sector, and proposes concrete, gender-intentional recommendations to bridge these gaps. The report highlights four focus areas: financial inclusion, skill development, market access, and policy and institutional support. It also showcases inspiring success stories of women entrepreneurs who are reshaping their communities and creating sustainable livelihoods.

I am confident that the insights and recommendations in this report will serve as a valuable resource for policymakers, industry stakeholders, and civil society as they work to design targeted interventions and build an enabling ecosystem for women entrepreneurs.

I sincerely hope that this work will inform future strategies and contribute meaningfully to enhancing women's participation in India's economic growth. I welcome your feedback and continued engagement in this vital endeavour.

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Abbreviations

ACIC GIETU	Atal Community Innovation Center - Gandhi Institute of Engineering and Technology University
ASUSE	Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises
ATUFS	Amended Technology Upgradation Scheme
AU	Authorised User
AYUSH	Ayurveda, Yoga & Naturopathy, Unani, Siddha and Homoeopathy
B2B	Business to Business
BC	Business Correspondents
BIS	Bureau of Indian Standards
CGTMSE	Credit Guarantee Fund Trust for Micro and Small Enterprises
COVID-19	CoronaVirus Disease 2019
CPR	Centre for Policy Research
CRY	Child Rights and You
CSIR	Council of Scientific and Industrial Research
DAY-NRLM	Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana - National Rural Livelihoods Mission
DBT	Direct Benefit Transfer
DDU-GKY	Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushalya Yojana
DDU-GKY	Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushal Yojana
DEPM	Directorate Of Export Promotion & Marketing
EPZ	Export Processing Zone
FGD	Focus Group Discussion
FPO	Farmer Producer Organization
FICCI-FLO	Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry – Ladies Organisation
GeM	Government e-Marketplace
GI	Geographical Indication
GMP	Good Manufacturing Practices
GSMA	Global System for Mobile Communications Association
GST	Goods and Service Tax
IAMAI	Internet and Mobile Association of India
ICRIER	Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations
IFC	International Finance Corporation
IME	Informal Micro Enterprise
INR	Indian Rupees
ISB	Indian School of Business

ISI	Indian Standards Institution
IT	Information Technology
ITI	Industrial Training Institutes
ITR	Income Tax Return
IWWAGE	Institute for What Works to Advance Gender Equality
JSS	Jan Shikshan Sansthan
KVIC	Khadi and Village Industries Commission
KVIC	Khadi and Village Industries Commission
MAITRI	Maharashtra Industry, Trade and Investment Facilitation Cell
MAITRI	Maharashtra Industry, Trade and Investment Facilitation Cell
MeitY	Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology
MGI	McKinsey Global Institute
MIS	Management Information System
MMF	Man Made Fibre
MNC	Multinational Corporation
MoU	Memorandum of Understanding
MSME	Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises
MSME-TEAM	MSME-Trade Enablement and Marketing
MUDRA	Micro Units Development and Refinance Agency
NABARD	National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development
NASSCOM	National Association of Software and Service Companies
NGO	Non-governmental organisation
NHDP	National Handloom Development Programme
NLP	Natural Language Processing
NPCI	National Payments Corporation of India
NRLM	National Rural Livelihoods Mission
NSDC	National Skill Development Corporation
NSS	National Sample Survey
NTFP	Non-Timber Forest Products
ODOP	One District One Product
ONDC	Open Network for Digital Commerce
PAN	Permanent Account Number
PLFS	Periodic Labour Force Survey
PM MITRA	Pradhan Mantri Mega Integrated Textile Region and Apparel
PMFME	Pradhan Mantri Formalisation of Micro food processing Enterprises
PMGDISHA	Pradhan Mantri Gramin Digital Saksharta Abhiyan
PMJDY	Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana

PMKVY	Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana
PMMY	Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana
PMVY	Pradhan Mantri Vishwakarma Yojana
PRA	Participatory Rural Appraisal
R&D	Research and Development
RBI	Reserve Bank of India
REED	Rural Economic and Enterprise Development
SC/ST	Scheduled Castes / Scheduled Tribes
SEWA	Self Employed Women's Association
SEZ	Special Economic Zone
SHG	Self Help Group
SPV	Special Purpose Vehicle
STEM	Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics
SWAYATT	Startups, Women and Youth Advantage Through e-Transactions
TAHDCO	Tamil Nadu Adi Dravidar Housing and Development Corporation
TRAI	Telecom Regulatory Authority of India
UN	United Nations
UPI	Unified Payments Interface
USD	United States Dollars
WEP	Women Entrepreneurship Platform
WHO	World Health Organisation
WMSME	Women-led Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises
ZED	Zero Defect Zero Effect

Acknowledgements

This report would not have been possible without the invaluable contributions of numerous individuals and organisations. We are immensely grateful for the support, insights, and encouragement provided by each person and institution involved.

First and foremost, we would like to extend our heartfelt thanks to the many female entrepreneurs, MSME employees, government officials, financial sector representatives, industry leaders, and community advocates who participated in our roundtable discussions. Many of them travelled significant distances to join these sessions and generously shared their time, experiences, and perspectives. Their in-depth insights into the daily realities, opportunities, and challenges faced by women entrepreneurs in the MSME sector provided the grassroot-level inputs for this report, making it richer. Without their thoughtful contributions, this research would lack the depth and practical relevance it seeks to achieve.

We are also profoundly grateful to our NGO partners for their extensive support and collaboration in organising these discussions. Their local expertise, networks, and commitment to the cause of women's empowerment were essential to the success of each roundtable. We extend special appreciation to Spandan and ACIC GIETU Foundation in Odisha, Bastar Samajik Jan Vikas Samiti in Chhattisgarh, Chaitanya in Maharashtra, SEWA in Gujarat and Uttar Pradesh, and CRY in Tamil Nadu. Each of these organisations works tirelessly on the ground to uplift female entrepreneurs and communities; we encourage our readers to explore their work and support their impactful initiatives.

Our deepest appreciation goes to Dr. Nandita Mondal, whose expert guidance and mentorship were instrumental throughout the research process. Dr. Mondal not only provided invaluable insights but also skilfully facilitated the discussions, helping draw out rich, nuanced perspectives that shaped the report. We are also grateful to Mr. Ishan Joshi, whose constructive feedback strengthened the quality of the analysis, and Ms. Neera Bali, who coordinated the roundtable discussions with dedication and attention to detail. We are continuously inspired by the unwavering encouragement and support provided by Dr. Rajiv Kumar and Mr. Ravi Pokharna, whose leadership and vision for inclusive growth have been a driving force for this project.

A special acknowledgement goes to the talented research team members, Ms. Garima Jain, Ms. Bharati Agarwal, Ms. Mahima Singh, and Ms. Surabhi Santhosh and Tushar. Their commitment, meticulous research, and organisational support were crucial in gathering, analysing, and synthesising information across states. They worked diligently behind the scenes to ensure that each piece of data was accurately captured, and every participant's voice was reflected in the report.

To everyone who contributed to this report, both directly and indirectly, we extend our sincerest gratitude. It is our hope that the findings and recommendations herein will honour your insights and contribute meaningfully to the advancement of female entrepreneurship in India.

Executive Summary

The Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprise (MSME) sector has been dubbed the backbone of the Indian economy, contributing 30% to GDP, 44% to exports, and 36% to manufacturing output.[1] Compared to large industries, MSMEs have a high labour-to-capital ratio and a more even geographical spread across India, making the sector a key driver of inclusive growth and employment.

Despite the economic and strategic importance of MSMEs, female participation in the sector remains disproportionately low, with only ~15 million out of 63 million MSMEs being women-owned. Women-owned MSMEs (WMSMEs) also tend to be smaller in size and face structural challenges to scaling; 20.44% of WMSMEs are micro enterprises, 5.26% are small, and only 2.77% are medium-sized.

This disparity underscores the urgent need for targeted measures to create an enabling ecosystem for women entrepreneurs. Bridging gender gaps in entrepreneurship is not only essential for advancing women's economic empowerment but also for unlocking the full potential of the MSME sector towards India's national goals. Given the fragmented nature of existing data, it is vital to explore causes at the grassroots level.

To this end, this study employed a mixed-methods approach, starting with consultative roundtables across six Indian states, inviting women entrepreneurs and key MSME ecosystem stakeholders (including bankers, government officials, Non-Government Organisation's (NGO) leaders, and industry association heads) to share their perspectives on the challenges faced by women entrepreneurs in the MSME sector. The qualitative insights received from the roundtables were then validated through

secondary research, which in turn was guided by the themes emerging from the discussions, ensuring both contextual richness and data-backed evidence. The resulting report puts forth actionable, gender-intentional strategies towards building a business ecosystem that supports women in starting, sustaining, and scaling their enterprises.

This report seeks to offer valuable insights for policymakers, civil society, and industry stakeholders committed to enhancing entrepreneurship and employment outcomes for women in India.

While not exhaustive, the following challenges are identified across four high-impact areas critical to building a supportive ecosystem for women in MSMEs: financial inclusion, skill development, market access, and policy and institutional support. It must be noted that these challenges are further exacerbated by social discrimination, low levels of financial literacy, the persistent digital divide, restricted geographical mobility, and the burden of household and childcare duties.

Financial Inclusion

- The gender gap in bank account ownership has virtually been eliminated, owing to financial inclusion programs like the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), but a 9% gender disparity in bank account usage remains.

- Formal credit usage is severely low among women entrepreneurs. WMSMEs face an estimated credit gap of US$ 1.4 trillion to US$ 1.7 trillion. 90% of women-owned businesses have never accessed formal credit in India. Women entrepreneurs tend to resort to informal credit sources, which often have higher interest rates and predatory practices.

- Patriarchal norms prevent women from independently owning an asset or a business, but lack of collateral is only one of many issues hindering access to formal credit. Credit received by women is only 27% of the deposits they contribute, compared to 52% for men. Notably, women's per capita savings exceed those of men, and they demonstrate lower credit risks. This indicates that a large number of credit-eligible women in India are underserved by financial institutions.

- On the supply side, financial institutions tend to often treat women borrowers as riskier due to limited credit histories, informal work profiles, lack of accounting records, and small loan sizes that are seen as commercially unviable. Unconscious gender biases may also play a role.

- On the demand side, women face challenges such as limited awareness of financial products, fear of default, risk aversion, past negative experiences contributing to distrust in the financial system, low confidence, distance from banks, and time-consuming and cumbersome procedures.

- It is easier for women entrepreneurs to access credit through microfinance institutions, self-help groups, and joint liability groups, than as an individual applicant.[2-3] A joint credit history and community accountability mechanisms can improve their commercial viability as borrowers.

- At the household level, women have limited autonomy over financial decisions and contribute larger portions of their income to household consumption, diverting funds away from business use.

Skill Development

- Despite significant progress in terms of gender parity in education (the Gender Parity Index is above 1 across all levels of education, indicating higher female enrollment than male enrollment), female labour force participation remains low at 41.7% (in the age 15+ category), compared to 78.8% for men, as of 2024.

- Skill training programmes have a leaky pipeline to employment and entrepreneurship. Women are 13 % less likely than men to receive job offers after training and 26 % less likely to accept them. They are also more likely to cite personal reasons like family concerns for rejecting offers, while men are more likely to cite work-related concerns.

- Social norms limit women to relatively low-paying sectors (e.g. tailoring, beauty, wellness, etc.), largely excluding them from more lucrative, high-growth industries like Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM). Moreover, women remain confined to lower rungs of the value chain within sectors, and have a greater tendency than men to work in informal jobs with low pay, poor job security, and limited opportunities for advancement.

Market Access

- A significant gender gap exists in forward market linkages, with women entrepreneurs, particularly in rural areas, having lower sales expectations and aspirations compared to men.
- Gender-inclusive sourcing through initiatives like the Public Procurement Policy and the Government e-Marketplace (GeM) portal helps improve market access but remains limited in scale. Moreover, it is estimated that women receive a very small share of private sector procurement.
- Information asymmetries between women-owned businesses and corporate buyers prevent effective linkages, with women entrepreneurs facing difficulties in meeting procurement standards and obtaining relevant information.
- Limited access to market intelligence hampers women entrepreneurs, who tend to rely on intermediaries instead of engaging directly with end consumers.
- Self-help group (SHG) participation can enhance forward market linkages through targeted training and marketing support.
- Digital platforms such as the NITI Aayog Women Entrepreneurship Platform, Udyam Sakhi, and various e-commerce marketplaces offer women entrepreneurs crucial access to information, networks, and wider markets, especially in remote areas. However, with Indian women 15% less likely to own a mobile phone and 33% less likely to use mobile internet than men, a persistent digital divide limits their ability to fully leverage these opportunities.[4]
- Despite digital infrastructure availability, actual usage by WSMEs usage remains low due to digital literacy gaps and cost barriers (e.g., e-store setup, payment integration, and digital marketing). Digital literacy gaps and cost barriers prevent online business growth, limiting reach and competitiveness.
- Lack of access to branding tools, affordable packaging, and mentorship restricts scalability and market integration.

Policy and Institutional Support

- India ranked 63rd in the World Bank Ease of Doing Business Index (2020), with regulatory inefficiencies noted as a specific constraint for scaling women-led enterprises.
- There is a lack of up-to-date, gender-disaggregated data for women-led MSMEs, limiting policymakers' ability to design targeted interventions. The last available data is from 2015-16, which is outdated and prevents the accurate identification of the specific challenges women entrepreneurs face. Regular, gender-disaggregated surveys are needed for better-targeted programs.

- Existing schemes suffer from gaps in beneficiary verification and fund utilisation. The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) reported issues like duplication of beneficiaries and underutilisation of funds, such as in the Ladli Scheme, where a significant amount of allocated funds remained unclaimed.
- Not all states have centralised platforms for business approvals and scheme applications. Platforms like Uttar Pradesh's Nivesh Mitra and Maharashtra's MAITRI portal streamline the process, making it more transparent and efficient for women entrepreneurs, reducing reliance on intermediaries.

The following policy recommendations are put forth across each of the four focus areas.

Financial Inclusion

01 **Strengthening the participation of women as banking agents and ombudsmen**
Encouraging more women to become banking agents and ombudsmen, through recruitment, training, and gender-sensitive policies, can help increase female financial inclusion and provide trusted channels for grievance redressal.

02 **Expansion of access to credit through digital lending and collateral-free products**
Digital lending platforms should offer accessible, collateral-free credit, with government-backed schemes improving outreach to women entrepreneurs.

03 **Leveraging self-help groups (SHGs) and community credit networks**
SHGs offer fast, flexible credit, and formalizing these groups with financial literacy and digital tools can improve access to finance for women entrepreneurs.

04 **Adoption of gender-responsive, alternative credit-scoring models**
Using non-traditional methods like psychometrics and mobile data to assess creditworthiness can increase women's access to loans, bypassing traditional barriers like lack of collateral and formal credit histories.

05 **Integrating financial services with women's existing digital touchpoints to improve uptake**
Embedding financial tools within platforms women already use, like e-commerce, can increase the adoption of digital payments and help build women's credit histories.

Market Access

01 **Building e-commerce and digital market competence through co-created training sessions by government bodies and e-commerce platforms**
Collaborations between government bodies and e-commerce platforms for digital marketing and logistics training can help women entrepreneurs tap into wider markets and enhance competitiveness.

02 **Improvement of market access through public procurement platforms**
Simplifying the onboarding process and offering technical support to women

entrepreneurs on platforms like GeM can increase their participation in government procurement, boosting market access.

03 **Bridging the private procurement gap through information dissemination on procurement standards and financial incentives**
Targeted awareness programs and incentives for corporations collaborating with women entrepreneurs can help bridge gaps in private procurement, expanding opportunities for women-owned MSMEs.

04 **Promotion of affordable production technology in traditional sectors towards quality enhancement**
Encouraging the adoption of low-cost, sector-specific production technologies can help women-owned MSMEs meet quality standards, improving their market access and competitiveness.

Skill Development

01 **Promotion of digital and financial literacy using community-based models**
Implementing scalable community-based literacy programs like "Digital Didi" and expanding initiatives such as Pradhan Mantri Gramin Digital Saksharta Abhiyan (PMGDISHA) can increase digital and financial literacy among rural women, supported by affordable smartphones and better last-mile connectivity.

02 **Implementation of inclusive and culturally appropriate capacity-building initiatives**
Entrepreneurial training programs should integrate indigenous knowledge, use participatory tools, and employ local trainers to ensure cultural relevance and accessibility for women with low literacy and time constraints.

03 **Evolving from skill development to holistic entrepreneurship development support**
Training programs should provide holistic support that combines technical, business, and life skills, aligned with market needs, and address challenges like family engagement, lost wage compensation, and childcare to ensure women's long-term success.

04 **Provision of mentorship and post-training support in sustaining entrepreneurial outcomes**
Providing mentorship and post-training support through digital platforms like the NITI Aayog Women Entrepreneurship Platform can help sustain entrepreneurial outcomes and reduce post-training drop-off.

Policy and Institutional Support

05 **Need for urgent implementation of gender-disaggregated data collection exercises for the MSME sector**
To inform targeted interventions for women-owned MSMEs (WMSMEs), there is an urgent need for gender-disaggregated MSME data, including through periodic surveys and censuses, to track needs and challenges, as evidenced by the success of global gender-specific data collection.

06 **Support of formalisation through awareness and registration assistance for the Udyam portal, GST filing, and women entrepreneurship schemes**
Organising cluster-based camps and mass awareness campaigns on formalisation processes like Udyam registration, GST filing, and women entrepreneurship schemes can facilitate women-led businesses' transition to the formal sector, enhancing access to benefits like credit and subsidies.

07 **Institutionalisation of female representation in decision-making bodies, from the panchayat level to the central government level**
Increasing representation of women in MSME advisory boards, credit review panels, and scheme monitoring committees is necessary to ensure women's perspectives are consistently integrated into policy-making processes at all levels of government.

01

Introduction

The Economic and Strategic Importance of the MSME Sector

Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) have been dubbed the backbone of the Indian economy. India is home to 63.39 million MSMEs, which contribute about 30% to the nation's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) and nearly 44% to its exports, underlining their critical role in driving economic growth and global competitiveness.[5] MSMEs account for approximately 36% of India's manufacturing output and have created around 20.5 crore jobs, as seen on the Udyam Registration Portal and Udyam Assist Platform.[6] Out of all the MSMEs in India, 51.25% (or 32.48 million) lie in rural areas and 48.75% (or 30.9 million) lie in urban areas.[7]

MSMEs have played a vital role in India by creating extensive job opportunities with lower capital costs compared to large industries.[8] With a higher labour-to-capital ratio and more even geographical spread across India than that of large industries, the MSME sector contributes significantly to the national objectives of growth, equity, and inclusion.[9] The development of the MSME sector can mobilise both unemployed labour and capital in India by absorbing surplus agricultural labour and complementing large industries as ancillary units. These characteristics make the MSME sector a key strategic asset for the Indian economy.

MSMEs account for approximately

36%

of India's manufacturing output and have created around 20.5 crore jobs, as seen on the Udyam Registration Portal and Udyam Assist Platform.

Table 1 Overview of India's MSME Sector

Category	Investment Limit	Annual Turnover Limit	Number	Sector
Micro	Up to INR 1 crore (US$ 0.12 million)	Up to INR 5 crore (US$ 0.60 million)	6,30,50,000 (or 99%)	19.7 million in manufacturing 23 million in trade 20.6 million in other services
Small	Up to INR 10 crore (US$ 1.20 million)	Up to INR 50 crore (US$ 6.04 million)	331,000 (or 0.52%)	
Medium	Up to INR 20 crore (US$ 2.41 million)	Up to INR 100 crore (US$ 12.07 million)	5000 (or 0.01%)	

Source: Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, Government of India. Annual Report 2023-24. 2024. msme.gov.in/sites/default/files/FINALMSMEANNUALREPORT2023-24ENGLISH.pdf.

[1] Throughout the report, the average exchange rate of US$ 1 = INR 82.79 for FY 2023-24 has been used. rbidocs.rbi.org.in/rdocs/Publications/PDFs/139T_13092024245FFE1BB8CB45C3A51183FB6ADA6DC8.PDF

As evident from Table 1, the MSME sector has been described as suffering from the problem of the missing middle, or the relative underrepresentation of medium-sized firms.[10] The micro-enterprises and own-account enterprises (OAEs) that typically serve hyper-local markets find it challenging to scale up their operations, impeding their chances of plugging into regional or global production networks. These challenges have prevented MSMEs from optimising their potential contribution to Indian economic growth.

1.1

The Role of Women in the MSME Sector

> According to the McKinsey Global Institute (MGI), India has the potential to increase its GDP by US$ 0.7 trillion if it integrates
>
> 
>
> **68 million more women**
>
> into the workforce by 2025.[11]

The World Bank has stated that India could raise its GDP growth by 1.5% points if 50% of women are included in the workforce.[12] However, India's female labour force participation rate (FLFPR), which had declined from 32% in 2005 to 19% in 2021–27% lower than the global average–has recently increased to around 31.7% in 2023, indicating a partial recovery though still marked by low-quality and informal employment.[13]

The MSME sector provides an important platform for marginalised groups, particularly women, to engage in employment or entrepreneurial activities, but the participation of women in the sector remains low, revealing persistent structural challenges. Only 15 million MSMEs are women-owned.[14] Compared to male-owned counterparts, female-owned MSMEs tend to operate on a smaller scale, are more concentrated in certain industries; 70% of women-owned MSMEs (WMSMEs) are involved in manufacturing, particularly in textiles, apparel, food and beverages, and handicraft.[15] Female-owned MSMEs also tend to be smaller in size and unable to scale, with 20.44% of WMSMEs being micro businesses, 5.26% being small businesses, and 2.77% being medium businesses.[16] When it comes to leadership roles, women's participation is a mere 10%.[17] Only 11.4% of entrepreneurs in India are women.[18]

The gender disparity suggests that targeted measures are needed to create an enabling environment for women within the MSME sector to facilitate their growth and participation in the economy.

The fragmented nature of current evidence, as well as the complex interplay of factors perpetuating the long-standing gender gap in entrepreneurship and employment, indicates a need to discuss their causes at the ground level, and amplify the voices of key stakeholders to fully harness the potential of the MSME sector towards India's national goals.

02

Objectives and Methodology

It is against this background that PIF conducted a detailed study on enhancing women's participation in the MSME sector, with the objective of identifying concrete and actionable policy recommendations towards building an enabling regulatory ecosystem for women's participation in the sector.

The study consciously made an effort to adopt core principles central to feminist research methodology. Cook and Fonow (1986) outline five such principles, which include centring women and gender in analytical frameworks; fostering awareness through consciousness-raising; challenging the dichotomy of the researcher and subject (i.e. recognising women participants' lived experiences as expert knowledge and acknowledging that research touted as "objective" is always shaped by the cultural context in which it is produced); maintaining a strong ethical focus throughout both the research process and its outcomes; and an intention to empower women and problematise existing power relations and inequalities.[19]

Given the lack of up-to-date, gender-disaggregated data on women in the MSME sector, it was essential to collect grassroots-level, granular insights into the challenges and opportunities for female entrepreneurs and employees in the MSME sector, and assess the take-up and impact of various government schemes and policies in this domain. There was also an urgent need to facilitate dialogue, cross-learning, and collaboration across various MSME stakeholders, as well as across states and sectors.

To this end, 12 consultative roundtables were conducted in six Indian states. In each state, a first session was held with female entrepreneurs and employees in the MSME sector to deliberate on the opportunities available and challenges they face in their line of work. These discussions were anchored by detailed background papers, prepared based on extensive secondary research.

A second session followed, gathering key MSME sector stakeholders from the state, including representatives from relevant government bodies, industry associations, community workers, and financial institutions. The second session aimed to table before the participants the perspectives shared by female entrepreneurs and jointly identify resolution mechanisms. The insights from the roundtables were collated into individual State Reports and synthesised into this National Report to draw state-wise comparisons and highlight best practices.

With 15 to 25 participants at each session, the roundtables provided a closed-door, Chatham House Rule-based platform to analyse issues and propose recommendations to address them. While the inputs collected cannot be considered representative of the universe of MSMEs, they serve as a dipstick survey of key stakeholders.

The insights shared by participants helped identify recurring points of contention and women-centric issues in the MSME sector in different states, demonstrated the role female entrepreneurship can play in socio-economic empowerment, and ultimately shed light on how a gender-intentional approach to MSME development can support economic and social gains. The qualitative insights received from the roundtables were then validated through secondary research, which in turn was guided by the themes emerging from the discussions, ensuring both contextual richness and data-backed evidence.

The sessions were skilfully moderated by Dr Nandita Mondal, Assistant Professor, School of Management and Labour Studies, Tata Institute of Social Sciences. A seasoned expert on women's work and dignity, she fostered a comfortable and flexible atmosphere to encourage candid and open dialogue, while maintaining an unwavering focus on the core issues.

Additionally, one-on-one interviews were conducted with a successful woman entrepreneur in each of the six states, deep diving into their entrepreneurial journey. These success stories are showcased at the end of this report to illustrate the enabling factors that drive women entrepreneurship.

Table 2 illustrates which states were selected for the roundtables and the rationale for their selection, based on their unique strengths and representation of diverse aspects. Table 3 presents a comparison of female entrepreneurship indicators in these states, including the number of women-owned Informal Micro Enterprises (IMEs), number of women-owned MSMEs, and percentage of women-owned MSMEs out of the total ecosystem.

Table 2 State-wise Workshops and Rationale for State Selection

State	Rationale for State Selection
Chhattisgarh	With a significant tribal population, Chhattisgarh was chosen to highlight the entrepreneurial efforts of women from tribal communities, offering insights into the workings of tribal ventures that are driven by indigenous knowledge, as well as the unique challenges tribal female entrepreneurs must overcome.
Gujarat	Gujarat, the largest contributor to India's overall exports, was included to examine how women entrepreneurs participate in trade-oriented sectors such as garments, embroidery, handicrafts, and chemicals, despite the absence of gender-disaggregated export data. The state also offers a unique lens on the success of women-led cooperative models, with SEWA providing a globally recognized example of collective enterprise building and market linkage.[20]
Maharashtra	Maharashtra has the highest absolute number of registered female-owned MSMEs in India, as per Udyam Registration data.[21] This allows us to explore the pathways to successful entrepreneurial ventures in areas where female presence in the MSME sector is already significant.

State	Rationale for State Selection
Odisha	Odisha offers the highest number of state schemes (41) supporting entrepreneurship.[22] Odisha thus provides a case study on how government support and enabling policy frameworks can foster female entrepreneurship.
Tamil Nadu	Tamil Nadu has the second highest absolute number of registered female-owned MSMEs in India, as per Udyam Registration data.[23]
Uttar Pradesh	Uttar Pradesh has the third highest absolute number of registered female-owned MSMEs in India, as per Udyam Registration data.[24]

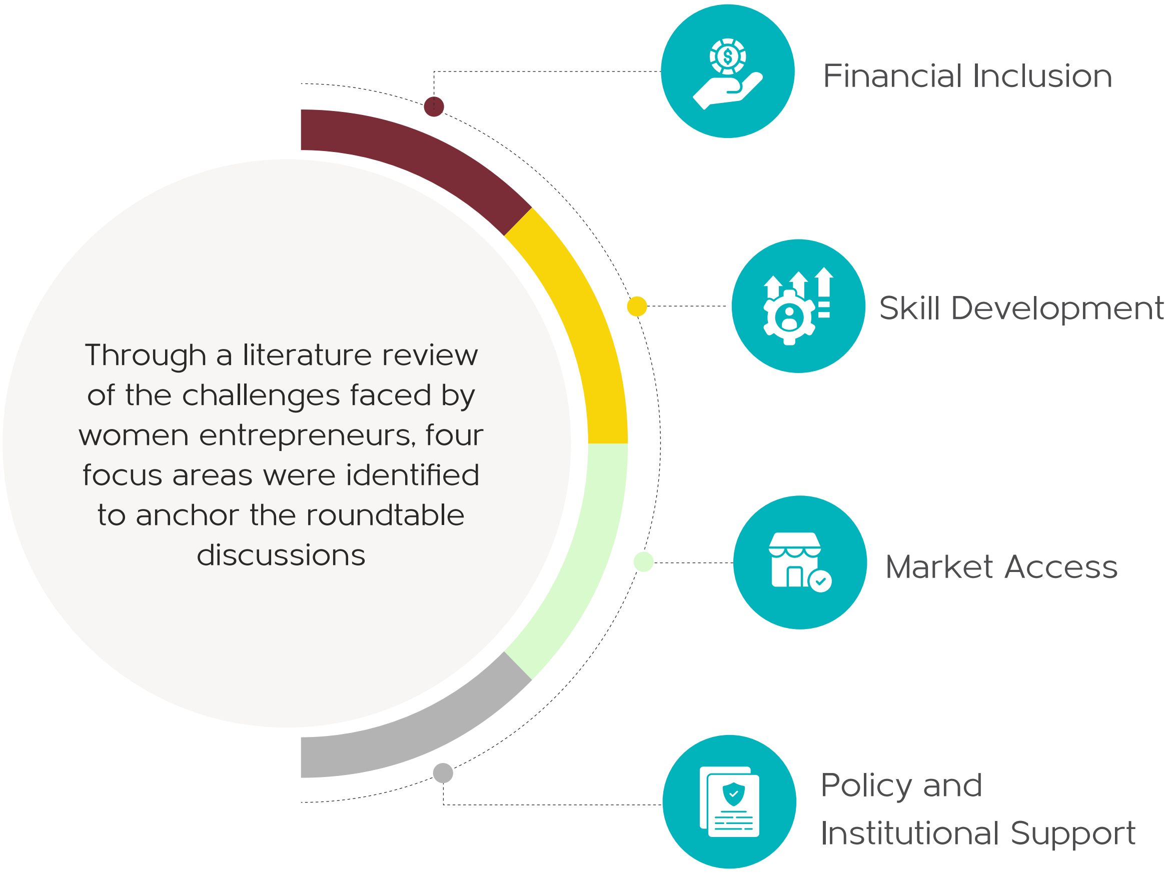
Table 3 State-wise Comparison of Female Entrepreneurship Indicators

State	Women-owned Informal Micro Enterprises (IMEs) (January 2024)	Women Owned MSMEs registered on Udyam Registration Portal and Udyam Assistance Portal as of Jan 2024	Percentage of women-owned MSMEs registered on Udyam Registration Portal and Udyam Assistance Portal as of Jan 2024
Chhattisgarh	1,843	53,914	42
Gujarat	302,580	252,551	28.00
Maharashtra	764,092	834,774	35.00
Odisha	374,612	106,656	44
Tamil Nadu	514,273	623,492	43.00
Uttar Pradesh	881,950	350,542	33
National Avg.	**253001**	**129,646**	**40**

Source: Press Information Bureau. Women Entrepreneurs in MSMEs. Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, Government of India. 5 February 2024. pib.gov.in/PressReleaseIframePage.aspx?PRID=2002574

03

Literature Review: Four Focus Areas



While this is far from an exhaustive list, these stand out as high-impact areas for targeted policy interventions. Narrowing the focus to key policy challenges allowed for targeted discussions and concrete recommendations. Together, these policy levers make up the foundation of a supportive business ecosystem where women entrepreneurs face minimal barriers to start, scale, and sustain their businesses.

First and foremost, it is crucial to highlight the sociocultural barriers that underpin all other policy challenges that follow.

- Women are expected to balance their business aspirations with domestic responsibilities, such as household chores and childcare, resulting in time poverty and a dual burden. Nearly 92% of women aged 15 to 59 report undertaking domestic chores at some time of the day, compared to only 27% of men, based on Time Use Survey (TUS) data from the NSSO.[25]

- Many women require approval from family members or societal sanction when making personal and/or professional decisions, and may encounter resistance.

- Women possess lower geographical mobility than men due to the social stigma associated with travelling solo. They often face familial restrictions on travelling alone or without a male relative, in addition to concerns about public safety, law and order, and other issues. Among all workers travelling to work outside the home, only 20% are women, as per 2011 Census data.[26]

- Women have a lower literacy rate than men. At the all-India level, the adult literacy rate in the 15-years-and-above category is 78.8% among males and 59.3% among females.

- India's persistent digital divide is especially concerning, given the increasing reliance on digital infrastructure. Indian women are 15 % less likely to own a mobile phone, and 33 % less likely to use mobile internet services than men, marking the widest gender gap in internet usage across the Asia-Pacific region.[27]

Financial Inclusion

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) defines financial inclusion as "the process of ensuring access to financial services and timely and adequate credit where needed by vulnerable groups such as weaker sections and low-income groups at an affordable cost."[28] In particular, access to credit is an important tool to support women's entrepreneurship. It enables them to manage working capital shortages, navigate pandemics and natural disasters, scale their ventures, modernise their operations by adoption of technology, and tap into higher rungs of the value chain. Below are some key trends in women and women entrepreneurs' access to finance:

The gender gap in bank account ownership has virtually been eliminated.

According to the Global Findex Database 2021, the gap decreased from 6% in 2017 to effectively zero in 2021, largely due to digital and financial inclusion programs like the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY).[29] 80.7% women in rural India and 81.3% of women in urban India have deposits in banks, as per the All India Debt and Investment Survey 2019.[30]

There is a disparity in bank account usage between genders.

The gender gap in terms of inactive bank accounts is 9%: 32% of women have an inactive account (i.e. no deposits or withdrawals, and no incoming or outgoing digital payments in the year prior to the survey), compared to 23% of men.[31] Women are 13% less likely than men to make or receive digital payments.[32] Given that financial institutions measure risk and assign credit in part based on applicants' transaction histories, low account usage is potentially a factor behind lack of access to credit.[33]

Formal credit usage among women entrepreneurs is severely low.

WMSMEs face an estimated credit gap of US$ 1.4 trillion to US$ 1.7 trillion.[34] 79% of women-owned businesses are self-financed.[35] Many women entrepreneurs in India, whether due to an inability or unwillingness to access formal credit, often resort to informal sources of finance. These sources typically come with higher interest rates and potentially predatory practices. 90% of women entrepreneurs in India rely on informal credit.[36]

The credit gap is likely attributable not only to the lack of collateral, but also to a variety of demand-side and supply-side factors.

Indeed, many women do not have property or assets in their name to leverage as collateral for loans, partially due to gender-biased inheritance rights. However, credit received by women is only 27% of the deposits they contribute, compared to 52% for men.[37] This disparity suggests that a large number of credit-eligible women in India are underserved by financial institutions. Notably, women's per capita savings exceed those of men, and they demonstrate lower credit risks across loan categories.[38]

On the supply side,

FGDs with women entrepreneurs revealed that unconscious gender biases continue to influence lending decisions, with many financial institutions perceiving women-led enterprises as higher risk. This perception is often linked to the limited digital and financial footprints of women entrepreneurs, especially those operating in the informal sector. Key challenges include the absence of formal accounting records, lack of a credit history, and difficulty in verifying consistent cash flows or market linkages. Furthermore, the relatively small loan amounts typically requested by women-led businesses are often seen as commercially unviable by lenders, reducing institutional motivation to extend support.[39]

On the demand side,

Women entrepreneurs commonly reported a lack of awareness and understanding of available financial products and services. Many felt that existing products were not tailored to their specific needs or business contexts. Risk aversion, compounded by fear of default and negative past experiences with formal financial institutions, emerged as significant deterrents. Additionally, participants cited the physical and procedural barriers–such as long distances to bank branches, time-consuming documentation, and complex processes–as reasons for their reluctance to engage. A general distrust of formal systems and low levels of financial confidence further contributed to the subdued demand for credit.[40]

While many of these barriers affect both men and women, their impact is often compounded for women.

Long distances to banks, exacerbated by limited geographical mobility, can make it difficult for women to access banking services. Additionally, time-consuming banking procedures often clash with domestic responsibilities, further hindering their ability to engage with formal financial institutions. Both actual and perceived social discrimination can also deter women from using these services, creating significant barriers to financial inclusion.

Loans, where given, are limited to small ticket sizes.

The Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana aims to advance women's financial inclusion by offering collateral-free loans of up to INR 1 million (US$ 12,078) to small and micro enterprises. In 2021, women entrepreneurs represented 68% of total loan recipients under this scheme, of which 88% fell under the 'Shishu' category, which is limited to amounts up to INR 50,000 (US$ 603.93).[41] Though many women drew benefits from the scheme, the loans disbursed were largely of low value and may not be adequate for business needs.

There is a "missing middle" problem in MSME financing.

While 60% of credit demand from micro-enterprises remains unmet by formal financial institutions, the equivalent figure is 70% for small enterprises. Medium enterprises are relatively well-equipped to access formal credit, and the credit needs of micro-enterprises can be met by microfinance institutions (MFIs). However, current RBI norms cap individual MFI loans at INR 1.25 lakh (or about US$ 1,509.84), limiting support for the small enterprises that may need higher credit.[42] Counterintuitively, small rather than micro WMSMEs may find it most difficult to access credit.

It is easier for women to access credit through microfinance institutions, self-help groups, and joint liability groups.

In 2017, individual women accounted for only 7% of total bank credit, as compared to 30% for men. When credit to microfinance institutions, self-help groups, and joint liability groups was included, women's share in total credit increased to 8%.[43] For women entrepreneurs, it is easier to access credit as part of an SHG, with a joint credit history and community accountability mechanisms, than as an individual applicant.

Women have limited control over household-level financial decisions and tend to contribute more to household expenses, restricting their funds for business use.

Only 18% of married women with earnings made autonomous decisions on how to spend their money, while 67% made decisions jointly with their spouses.[44] Women also contribute larger portions of their income to household consumption than men.[45]

Table 4 presents a comparison of indicators relevant to financial inclusion across the selected states, namely the number of women-owned bank accounts and the number of "Lakhpati Didis" under the Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana - National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM). DAY-NRLM, which organizes rural poor women into Self Help Groups, has adopted the "Lakhpati Didi" initiative to support SHG women in earning a minimum annual income of INR 1 lakh (or about US$ 1,207.87). This indicator is included as SHG membership has been shown to enhance women's access to credit.

Table 4 State-wise Comparison of Indicators Relevant to Financial Inclusion

State	Women-owned bank accounts (PMJDY) FY 2020-21	Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana – National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM) Beneficiaries in 2023-24 (i.e. number of Lakhpati Didis)
Chhattisgarh	85,30,820	3,37,097
Gujarat	81,03,620	5,38,760
Maharashtra	1,62,80,707	10,04,338
Odisha	96,18,099	5,37,350
Tamil Nadu	65,41,221	3,18,101
Uttar Pradesh	3,90,12,636	8,41,923
National Avg.	**64,94,738**	**3,38,243**

Sources: PIB Press Release. "Details of the total number of women who have benefited from the Lakhpati Didi and Namo Didi initiatives, State-wise and category-wise." 12 December 2024. pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2080093. Ranjan, Ranjeet, K.C. Venugopal, Amee Yajnik, Ministry of Finance, and Department of Financial Services. "Implementation of PMJDY." Rajya Sabha, February 6 2024. sansad.in/getFile/annex/263/AU361.pdf?source=pqars&.

Skill Development

Attending skilling or vocational training programmes is correlated with a higher likelihood of employment among women. This holds true at all levels of education.[46] The Government of India has promoted an expansive set of programmes for the education and skilling of women. These include Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP), Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs), Pradhan Mantri Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY), Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Grameen Kaushal Yojana (DDU-GKY), Jan Shikshan Sansthan (JSS), Pradhan Mantri Vishwakarma Yojana (PMVY), and the National Apprenticeship Promotion Scheme (NAPS). Below are some key trends in women and women entrepreneurs' education and skill development.

Despite growing parity in educational enrolment, a significant gender gap in labour force participation persists.

The Gender Parity Index across education levels is above 1.00, indicating that female enrolment is higher compared to male enrolment in education, but only 41.7% of women aged 15 and above participate in the labour force as of 2024, compared to 78.8% of men in the same category.[47]

Women's education has a U-shaped relationship with labour force participation in India.

Women with low or high levels of education are more likely to be employed, while those with moderate education levels are less likely to work. This trend is influenced by social norms, the availability of suitable jobs, and household income effects.[48]

In skilling programs, there is a leaky pipeline for women from training to employment or entrepreneurship.

Male trainees of Skill India are 13 % likely than women to receive a job offer at the end of their training. They are 26 % more likely to accept these offers. Women often decline offers due to personal affairs, family, and migration concerns, while men tend to reject offers due to work-related concerns like inadequate pay.[49]

Women train and work in less technologically sophisticated and less lucrative sectors than men.

Social norms play a key role in defining which trades are considered suitable for women. Women dominate the arts, education, and medical science fields, while men dominate engineering, IT, and technology-related fields at the graduate level.[50] In skilling programs, women primarily enrol in courses like apparel, beauty, and wellness under PMKVY and dressmaking, secretarial practice, cosmetology, fashion design, and interior design under ITIs. Few women take courses in priority sectors (i.e. those projected by the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship to create jobs in the future), engineering-related courses, construction and real estate, transportation and logistics, electronics, IT hardware, the auto industry, and the pharma industry.[51] This limits women to the production of traditional goods or services, with low representation in sectors that require higher levels of technical education and that offer higher returns. Moreover, women workers remain confined to lower rungs of the value chain within sectors, with a greater tendency than men to work in informal jobs with low pay and poor job security.[52]

Flexible arrangements increase women's take-up of skilling programmes and jobs.

Out-of-labour-force women strongly desire training for non-traditional (part-time and potentially home-based) work. Such flexible arrangements bridge the gap between traditional household duties and formal jobs and can serve as a stepping stone for future full-time employment.[53]

To be effective, skilling programmes must comprehensively prepare women for employment and entrepreneurship.

The Kudumbashree programme in Kerala is a good example of comprehensive entrepreneurship development, but is not the norm.[54] The focus must be shifted from technical skilling to holistic, future-proof entrepreneurship development, including training in core business skills across financial and digital literacy, marketing, accounting, inventory management, vendor negotiation, selling on e-commerce platforms, and other areas. The syllabus must be continually updated to remain aligned with market needs. Motivation training and life skills must be emphasised as much as technical and business skills.

Training programs must address gendered constraints in their design.

To allow women to engage fully and reap benefits from skilling programs, family members should be invited to workshops to foster long-term support systems, given that women often require familial permission to work. Additionally, compensation for lost wages must be offered, childcare provisions should be made available, safe transportation must be supported, and sexual harassment must be prevented and addressed. The World Bank highlights several global examples where gender-responsive training design has yielded positive outcomes: in Colombia, the Jóvenes en Acción youth training program increased participation among women with young children by offering childcare subsidies and on-site day care. Similarly, Peru's ProJoven program addressed mobility-related barriers by doubling stipends for female trainees with children under five to cover transportation, meals, and medical insurance, resulting in long-term improvements in women's employment outcomes.[55]

Table 5 presents a comparison of indicators relevant to skill development across the selected states. These indicators include the female literacy rate, the percentage of women who attained higher secondary education, and the number of female candidates certified under the basic skill training component of the PM Vishwakarma Yojana.

Table 5 State-wise Comparison of Indicators Relevant to Skill Development

State	Female literacy rate as per 2011 Census	Percentage of women who attained higher secondary education as per PLFS 2021-22	Number of female candidates certified under Basic Skill Training offered by PM Vishwakarma Yojana as of July 2024
Chhattisgarh	60.6	13.1	9,252
Gujarat	70.7	9.2	37,984
Maharashtra	75.5	12.8	14,679
Odisha	64.4	8.6	1,480
Tamil Nadu	73.9	13	(Data unavailable)
Uttar Pradesh	59.3	10.9	8,338
National Avg.	**64.6**	**18.2**	**10,988**

Sources: Annual Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) Report 2021-22. GoI. dge.gov.in/dge/reference-publication-reports-annual. Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India, Census of India 2011 (New Delhi: Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India, 2011) censusindia.gov.in/census.website/
Press Information Bureau, Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, Government of India, "Women Beneficiaries in PM Vishwakarma Scheme," July 22, 2024, pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2034991

Market Access

WMSMEs being unable to effectively sell their products or services beyond their local vicinity, limits their potential for growth, expansion, and integration into larger value chains. Moreover, women entrepreneurs have limited access to industry contacts, professional networks, mechanisms and the overall know-how necessary for running and growing a business. These issues are especially striking for women in rural areas. As a result, female-owned MSMEs are unable to scale and are largely limited to micro-enterprises.

A gender gap persists in terms of forward market linkages.

A significant share of self-employed women are subsistence entrepreneurs, running their enterprises without hired help. 27% of rural women use all their produce for household consumption (vs. 10% of men), and only 36% aim to sell half or more of their output (vs. 45% of men). Urban women show higher sales aspirations but still lag behind their male counterparts.[56] Women entrepreneurs have lower sales expectations than men; scholars argue that this reflects a gender gap in forward market linkages.

Women are disproportionately affected by cross-cutting barriers to market access.

According to the PLFS 2024, self-employment is higher in rural areas. Overall, 67% of working women are self-employed, while this figure rises to 73% for working women specifically in rural areas.[57] Entrepreneurs in rural areas face significant hurdles in accessing markets due to distance from major markets and poor transport and logistics infrastructure. For women entrepreneurs, this obstacle is further compounded by restrictive social norms that limit their geographical mobility, as well as household or childcare duties.

Additionally, a persistent digital divide hinders women's access to market intelligence, professional networks, procurement mechanisms, digital marketing opportunities, and digital sales channels like e-commerce platforms.

Gender-inclusive sourcing plays a major role in driving market access for women entrepreneurs and must be prioritised.

Under the Public Procurement Policy, central public sector enterprises must make at least 3% of their annual procurement from WMSMEs.[58] The Government e-Marketplace (GeM) portal and associated initiatives like Startups, Women & Youth Advantage through eTransactions (SWAYATT) and Womaniya offer an open and inclusive platform to connect government buyers with women entrepreneurs and self-help groups. Women entrepreneurs comprise 8% of the total seller base on GeM. 1.8 lakh Udyam-verified wmsmare registered on the portal, and they have fulfilled a cumulative order value of INR 46,615 crore.[59] When it comes to the private sector, women receive only 1% of MNCs' US$ 4 trillion annual procurement spend. These figures ought to be higher.

Information frictions hinder effective linkages between corporate buyers and women entrepreneurs.

The International Finance Corporation (IFC) notes that women-owned businesses lack access to critical information about corporate procurement requirements and processes, including what is being purchased, how purchases occur, and what kind of standards are in place. Given that WMSMEs tend to be micro-businesses, they also face financing, capacity, and volume constraints that prevent them from bidding for larger contracts. Additionally, corporate buyers struggle to identify reliable women-owned supplier. They may not understand the challenges faced by women entrepreneurs when it comes to meeting procurement standard. On top of that, they may be unaware of how to make their supplier onboarding processes more inclusive and accessible to WMSMEs.[60] Efforts are underway to bridge these information asymmetries. WEConnect International, a global non-profit organisation, connects women-owned businesses with multinational and large companies sourcing goods from MSMEs. Supplier databases, buyer-seller meets, and trade promotion events may also help bridge the gap.

E-commerce creates business opportunities for women entrepreneurs by offering them greater flexibility.

The World Bank notes that e-commerce increases market linkages for previously-excluded or discouraged people like women, the youth and the unemployed by mitigating geographical and locational barriers, allowing them to access the wider domestic market and also international markets.[61] Women-entrepreneurs, including those in remote areas, are empowered by e-commerce to start businesses at home and work flexible hours. Moreover, in India, the government-run Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC) has emerged as a catalyst for women entrepreneurship by democratising e-commerce. As of July 2024, 400 women-led businesses have been onboarded on ONDC, supporting the livelihoods of over 50 lakh women.[62]

Women entrepreneurs, especially in rural areas, often face limited access to market intelligence.

Information on market trends, customer preferences, and competitor activities is difficult to access for women entrepreneurs, particularly those in remote areas, due to digital exclusion, restricted mobility, and lack of access to mentorship and professional networks. As a result, they frequently rely on intermediaries, which reduces direct engagement with end consumers and hampers feedback loops that are crucial for competitive growth.

SHG participation can support forward market linkages.

The success of Okhai, a handicraft brand built by self-help groups, is attributed to targeted training and marketing guidance that ensured the alignment of traditional designs with contemporary consumer preferences.[63] Similarly, Lijjat Papad, a women-led cooperative, scaled their operations by accurately assessing market demand and aligning production accordingly.[64]

Digital technology acts as a great leveller, making it crucial to bridge the digital divide.

Female entrepreneurs use social media for low-cost marketing, communication with buyers and sellers, sales coordination, and gathering customer preference data.[65] Chetna Sinha, Founder of Mann Deshi Foundation, highlighted how WhatsApp became a powerful equaliser for women entrepreneurs during the pandemic. The application's accessible and user-friendly interface enabled rural women to continue running their businesses digitally.[66] The NITI Aayog's Women Entrepreneurship Platform and the Ministry of MSMEs' Udyam Sakhi provide online resources and professional networks for women entrepreneurs.

Table 6 presents a comparison of indicators relevant to market access across the selected states. This includes the female labour force participation rate (reflecting women's ability to access the labour market), number of micro enterprises owned by women, micro enterprises as a percentage of total women-owned MSMEs (reflecting the limited ability of women-owned enterprises to scale up), and the number of Internet subscribers per 100 population (given that digital connectivity helps women access market intelligence, digital marketing opportunities, and digital sales channels like e-commerce).

Table 6 State-wise Comparison of Indicators Relevant to Market Access

State	Female LFPR (%) in the age category 15-59 in 2023-24	Number of micro enterprises owned by women as of November 2024	Internet Subscribers per 100 population as of September 2022
Chhattisgarh	63.6	52,811	51.08
Gujarat	50.9	246,403	72.05
Maharashtra	44.4	825,120	79.81
Odisha	53.5	105,041	48.89
Tamil Nadu	47	615,385	72.88
Uttar Pradesh	35.8	343,917	45.51
National Avg.	**45.2**	**127,626**	**61.62**

Source: Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, Government of India, Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), Annual Report 2023-24, National Statistical Office. mospi.gov.in/sites/default/files/publication_reports/AnnualReport_PLFS2023-24L2.pdf
Press Information Bureau. Women Entrepreneurs in MSMEs. Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, Government of India. 5 February 2024. pib.gov.in/PressReleaseIframePage.aspx?PRID=2002574
.Lok Sabha, Internet Connectivity in Rural Areas, February 15, 2023, sansad.in/getFile/loksabhaquestions/annex/1711/AU2351.pdf?source=pqals.

Policy and Institutional Support

Business compliance is a cumbersome process for all entrepreneurs, by many accounts. Doing business requires adhering to various norms such as business registration, labour law compliance, taxation, environmental and safety regulations, financial reporting and audits, electricity and infrastructure standards, and other sector-specific licenses, all of which typically fall under multiple regulators. Commonly cited pain points include complex regulatory procedures, lack of single-window clearance, delays in obtaining permits, and inefficiencies in administrative processes.

While these challenges affect all MSMEs, they are particularly severe for women entrepreneurs due to limited access to information and support services, lower digital and financial literacy, time poverty due to domestic responsibilities, and mobility constraints. While there are many state and central schemes, subsidies, incentives, tax/duty exemptions, and training opportunities in place to support women entrepreneurs, there is also a need to improve awareness. Additionally, efforts should be made to increase the uptake of the support available and to enhance monitoring and evaluation processes to ensure that they lead to better outcomes for women entrepreneurs.

Up-to-date, gender-disaggregated data for WMSMEs is largely absent.

The lack of updated, gender-disaggregated data limits policymakers' ability to design targeted interventions for WMSMEs. The last detailed gender-disaggregated MSME data available in India is from the National Sample Survey (NSS) 73rd round (2015-16), with outdated information on the needs and challenges of women-led businesses. This gap restricts the identification of specific pain points faced by women entrepreneurs. Conducting periodic gender-disaggregated MSME surveys can provide the necessary data to guide targeted programmes. Research from global contexts, such as the UN Women's Gender Data Gaps Report, illustrates that regular, gender-specific data collection allows for better-targeted interventions.

Not all states have single-window platforms in place for business approvals and scheme applications.

A central platform, as seen with Uttar Pradesh's Nivesh Mitra portal and Maharashtra's MAITRI portal, can streamline applications, eliminate intermediaries, and offer a checklist of eligibility and documentation requirements in one place. This approach makes the process transparent and efficient for women entrepreneurs.

Table 7 presents a comparison of indicators relevant to policy and institutional support across the selected states. These indicators include their rank in the Business Reform Action Plan 2020, reflecting ease of doing business (which is gender-agnostic), and the number of state-level schemes supporting women entrepreneurship.

Table 7 State-wise Comparison of Indicators Relevant to Policy and Institutional Support

State	Ease of Doing Business Rank (Business Reforms Action Plan 2020)	Number of schemes supporting women entrepreneurship as of 2022
Chhattisgarh	Aspirers	11
Gujarat	Top Achievers	18
Maharashtra	Achievers	2
Odisha	Achievers	41
Tamil Nadu	Top Achievers	22
Uttar Pradesh	Achievers	12

Sources: PIB Press Release, Assessment of States/UTs based on implementation of Business Reforms Action Plan for the year 2020 declared. 30 June 2022. pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1838178
NITI Aayog, Decoding Government Support to Women Entrepreneurs in India: The Anatomy of Entrepreneurship Support Schemes. October 2022. niti.gov.in/sites/default/files/2023-03/Decoding-Government-Support-to-Women-Entrepreneurs-in-India.pdf.

04

Support Schemes for Female Entrepreneurship

The Government of India (GoI) has rolled out schemes to support the growth of entrepreneurs and enterprises in the MSME sector, with additional incentives for women. The following are some of the key national initiatives

Credit Schemes

Skill Development Schemes

Market Access Schemes

Other Schemes

Credit Schemes

01 **Micro and Small Enterprises Cluster Development Programme**[67, 68]

- Establishment of common facility centres across the country to address the common issues such as technology improvement, skill development, and quality enhancement.
- Eligible project costs of up to INR 15 crore (US$ 1.81 million), with a 70% contribution from the GoI, the contribution share rises to 90% for clusters with more than 50% women units.
- Approval for a total of 580 projects under the programme, with 308 projects completed.

02 **Credit Guarantee Scheme for Micro and Small Enterprises**[69, 70]

- Provision of guarantee cover for collateral-free and third-party guarantee-free credit facilities extended by eligible Member Lending Institutions to MSMEs.
- Guarantee coverage of up to 85% for women, compared to 75% for others.
- A 10% concession in annual guarantee fee for women.

03 **Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana**[71, 72]

- Aims to provide collateral free institutional credit to Small and Micro enterprises up to INR 10 lakh US$ 12,078.75 (Shishu, Kishor, and Tarun) through member lending institutes.
- Revision of the limit of INR 20 lakh US$ 24,157.50 for those who repaid full amount under the Tarun category.
- Out of total 44.46 crore loans sanctioned under Yojana, 30.64 crore (69%) have been sanctioned to women.

Skill Development Schemes

01 Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme[73]

- A credit-linked subsidy scheme for providing employment opportunities through establishment of micro-enterprises in the non-farm sector.
- Margin money subsidy of 35% available to women beneficiaries, compared to 25% for the non-special category, more than 1.6 lakh women units assisted between FY19 and FY25 (up to July 2024).

02 Entrepreneurship and Skill Development Programme[74, 75]

- A skill training programme module providing technical and business skills to entrepreneurs ranging from 1 day to 180 days.
- Since the time of approval of its revised guidelines (March 2022), more than 11 lakh beneficiaries have been trained under the programme, of which about 50% are women.

Market Access Schemes

01 Udyam Sakhi Portal

- An online platform designed to support women entrepreneurs by providing access to information on business strategies, financial assistance, and skill-building resources.
- Offers end-to-end assistance, acting as a one-stop solution for aspiring women entrepreneurs.
- Digital approach makes accessing resources more manageable, especially in rural and semi-urban areas where in-person access to support may be limited.

02 Mahila E-Haat

- Initiative to promote direct market access for women entrepreneurs.
- A digital platform that allows women to showcase and sell their products directly to consumers.
- Encourages rural women artisans and entrepreneurs to enter the digital market, overcoming barriers of geographical limitations and middlemen, thereby improving profitability.

03 MSME-TEAM (Trade Enablement and Marketing) Initiative

- An initiative to promote onboarding of women micro and small enterprises on the ONDC platform.
- Provides financial assistance for catalogue preparation, account management, logistics and packaging material and design.
- Informal enterprises (even without a GST) are also encouraged to become part of the e-commerce trade.

Other Schemes

01 One District, One Product (ODOP) Scheme

- The scheme focuses on building product clusters at the district level, providing infrastructure, market access, and institutional support that helps micro and small enterprises thrive. While not exclusive to women, ODOP has a significant impact on women entrepreneurs, particularly in sectors like handicrafts, textiles, and food processing. Women entrepreneurs benefit from targeted training and the opportunity to scale within supportive local ecosystems. While Uttar Pradesh is early to leverage the scheme, other states are also at different stages of implementation.

02 Zero Defect Zero Effect (ZED) Scheme

- The scheme envisages that MSMEs should manufacture products that have no defects and no effect on the environment. Towards this end, the ZED model is designed to make aware, assess, certify, counsel, and handhold MSMEs to achieve ZED certification reducing their wastage and increasing their productivity. Under this scheme, there is a provision of 100% subsidy on cost of ZED Certification for women-owned MSMEs.

The above list, although not exhaustive, sheds light on some of the key schemes that the government has rolled out for the benefit of MSMEs, with a gender-intentional approach to promote female entrepreneurship. Additionally, the following best practices and initiatives have been implemented across India to support and promote female entrepreneurship:

Annapurna Scheme (State Bank of Mysore)

This loan scheme targets women in the food business, providing financial support to set up and sustain food-related businesses. The scheme is particularly beneficial for low-income entrepreneurs in rural areas and urban fringes. Women are offered capital to purchase utensils, equipment, and other essentials, with repayment terms that consider their unique circumstances and constraints, making it easier for them to maintain operations.

Sakhi Mandals in Gujarat (Gujarat Government)

Gujarat's model of women's Self-Help Groups (SHGs), particularly under the Gujarat Livelihood Promotion Company, offers support to women in rural areas. These Sakhi Mandals work as collective enterprises, where women pool resources to scale up their businesses. The program also includes capacity-building workshops, market linkage support, and financial literacy training, which strengthens the autonomy and economic stability of women entrepreneurs.

Udyogini Scheme (Government of Karnataka)

The Udyogini Scheme offers loans specifically to women from economically weaker sections. This initiative promotes entrepreneurship among rural women by providing capital and training in various industries like handicrafts, dairy, and tailoring. The scheme has shown success in creating a sustainable livelihood model for women with minimal financial resources and limited formal education.

Stree Nidhi (Government of Telangana)

It is a community-based credit cooperation scheme with an objective to provide micro credit to women members of self-help groups and supplement the credit flow from the banking sector. It runs on the corpus provided partly by self-help groups through block and town level federations, and partly by the government. With a facility to avail a loan within 48 hours, Stree Nidhi credit can be obtained on all days of the week.

Tejaswini Scheme (Jammu and Kashmir)

A financial assistance scheme which offers business loans up to INR 5 lakh (US$ 6,039.37) to young women entrepreneurs (18-35 years of age) with a provision of interest subsidy of up to INR 60,000 (US$ 724.72) effectively making the loan interest-free.

Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC) Programmes

KVIC initiatives across states provide support to women involved in traditional industries such as khadi, handicrafts, and agro-processing. KVIC offers training and funds to facilitate the transition of women-led enterprises from informal to formal structures. The programmes also support marketing efforts to expand reach beyond local markets, ensuring better revenue for women entrepreneurs.

These best practices from various Indian states highlight the importance of customised schemes that address the unique challenges faced by women entrepreneurs. They combine financial support, digital access, training, and market linkage to create a more conducive environment for women-led enterprises across the country.

05

Sectoral Analysis

The three sectors of the MSME universe where female participation – both in the workforce and as entrepreneurs – is relatively high are: textiles and apparel, handicrafts, and food processing. The figure below provides a snapshot of the three sectors. To boost economic opportunities in these sectors, multiple schemes at both the central and state levels are in operation, providing both fiscal and non-fiscal incentives.

Table 8 Overview of Textiles & Apparel, Handicrafts, and Food Processing Sector

	Textiles & Apparel	Handicrafts	Food Processing
Market Size	-$197 billion (FY23) - $350 billion (FY30)	- $4.2 billion (2023) - $7.8 billion (2032)	- $866 billion (2022) - $1.2 trillion (2027)
GDP Contribution	2.3% to total GDP	0.12% to total GDP	1% to total GDP
Employment	Provides livelihood to 45 million people	Provides livelihood to 7 million people	Provides livelihood to 7 million people
Role of Women	62% of total workers are female	56% of total artisans are female	24% of total workers are female
Sector Specific Attribute(s)	- 2nd largest textile producer in the world - 3rd largest exporter of textiles & apparel	-744 clusters with over 35,000 products -56% of all artisans are female	- Largest milk producer in the world - 2nd largest producer of fruits & vegetables in the world - 2nd largest egg and fish producer and 5th largest meat producer in the world

Source: ASUSE (2023-24), PLFS (2023-24), IBEF, and other market studies

5.1

Textiles and Apparel

Overview

The textile sector is one of the largest sectors in the Indian manufacturing space. With a large number of units engaged in activities like spinning, weaving, knitting, and manufacturing of various products like rugs, carpets, rope, fur, boots, and other related articles, this sector caters to both the Indian and the international market with a market size of about US$ 197 billion.[76]

Women are more involved in this sector because of its inherently decentralised and low skill-intensive nature – essentially comprising multiple albeit simple tasks contrary to what may be required, for instance, in aluminium die casting or iron smelting in the heavy industry sector. Since individual tasks can be segmented into multiple activities, it also creates a business/entrepreneurship opportunity for women where they can single out a particular activity/task and cater to that requirement (which initially requires a small amount of investment) without the need to establish a separate unit. Examples include home-based activities or household run own-account enterprises.[2] This makes the sector not just a source of employment but a socio-economic empowerment lever too, especially for rural and semi-urban women. It provides a flexible work environment that allows women to balance household responsibilities while being in the workforce, and facilitates the transmission of skills across generations. For these reasons, the textile and apparel sector is one of the largest employers of women.

[2] An establishment which is run without any hired worker employed (ASUSE, 2023-24).

The figure below provides an overview of the sector.

Figure 1 Sectoral Overview of the Indian Textiles and Apparel Sector

Textiles & Apparel

- Employs about 45 million people
- Expected CAGR of 10%
- 2nd largest producer of textile in the world
- 3rd largest exporter of textiles and apparel in the world
- Contributes 2.3% to GDP
- Part of PLI scheme with an outlay of $1.44 billion
- 62% of total workers are female
- Market size of $197 billion (FY23)

National Schemes

PM Mega Integrated Textile Region and Apparel (PM MITRA) Parks[77, 78]

- Textile park to be set-up in an area of more than 1000 acres in the Lucknow-Hardoi region
- Greenfield investment by GoI includes capital support @30% with a cap of INR 500 crore (US$ 60.39 million)
- Brownfield investment by Central government includes balance project cost @30% with a cap of INR 200 crore (US$ 24.15 million)
- Project will enhance the textile manufacturing ecosystem in Hardoi, providing state-of-the-art infrastructure, sustainable production practices, and significant employment opportunities, particularly for women in the textile sector

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 4,445 crore (US$ 536.90 million)	• Investment MoUs worth INR 18,500 crore (US$ 2.23 billion) have been signed by potential investors	• Lowering access barriers to modern industrial infrastructure for women entrepreneurs • More employment opportunities

National Handloom Development Programme (NHDP)[79, 80, 81, 82]

- Aims to bolster India's handloom sector and improve the lives of handloom weavers
- Offers assistance in raw material procurement, design inputs, technology up-gradation, marketing support through exhibitions, setting-up of infrastructure, and other related activities
- Components include cluster development, marketing assistance, concessional credit, handloom weavers' welfare, among other miscellaneous components
- Financial assistance ranges from INR 500 to INR 30 crore (US$ 60.39 million to US$ 3.62 million) on project basis

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 837 crore (US$ 101.09 million)	• An amount of about INR 700 crore (US$ 84.55 million) has been released	• A 100% subsidy is provided to women weavers for construction of work sheds under the NHDP

Amended Technology Upgradation Fund Scheme (ATUFS)[83, 84, 85, 86]

- Credit-linked capital subsidy scheme for investment in textile manufacturing
- Capital investment subsidy @15% with a cap of INR 30 crore (US$ 3.62 million) for textiles and garments
- Coverage includes entities belonging to handloom, silk, jute, textiles, garments, processed fibres, and weaving & knitting sectors

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 17,822 crore (US$ 2.15 billion)	• A total capital investment subsidy of INR 1,855 crore (US$ 224.06 million) has been released	• Out of a total 3.9 lakh new jobs generated, women have availed of 1.12 lakh (29%) jobs

State Schemes

State	Scheme	Relevance
Chhattisgarh	Industrial Policy 2019-24[87]	• Textile (spinning, weaving, power loom and fabrics & other processes) is identified as a high-priority industry under the state's industry policy • In addition to the incentives for MSMEs (capital subsidy, interest subsidy, SGST reimbursement, etc.), industries set up by women entrepreneurs will receive 10% additional incentives, a 10% higher ceiling of incentives, and an extended time limit of one additional year
Gujarat	Gujarat Textile Policy 2024[88]	• Interest subsidy of 7% • Power tariff subsidy of INR 1/unit (Kwh) • Payroll assistance of INR 5,000 (US$ 60.39) per female worker (garment, apparels, & made-ups)
Maharashtra	Integrated & Sustainable Textile Policy 2023-28[89]	• Capital subsidy up to 45% • Additional capital subsidy of 5% for units being run by women (provided that more than 50% of the employees are women) • Power tariff subsidy of up to INR 3.77/unit (Kwh)
Odisha	• Odisha Apparel and Technical Textiles Policy 2022[90] • Industrial Policy Resolution (IPR) 2022[91]	• Capital investment subsidy of up to 40% • Employment subsidy of INR 6,000 (US$ 72.47) per female worker • Textiles identified as a thrust sector under the IPR 2022 (thrust sectors are eligible for additional incentives on top of what is given to other sectors) • Power tariff subsidy of INR 2/unit (Kwh)
Tamil Nadu	• Special Scheme for Technical Textiles, MMF (Man Made Fibre) Yarn from Recycled Products, MMF Fabric & Apparel Manufacturing 2023[92] • Tamil Nadu New Integrated Textile Policy 2019[93] • Mini Textile Park Scheme 2015[94]	• Capital subsidy of 15% • Electricity tax exemption for a period of five years • Training subsidy of INR 6,000 (US$ 72.47) per female worker per six months • Interest subsidy for primary Handloom Weavers Co-operative Societies enhanced to 6% • Credit linked capital investment subsidy @10% for power loom sector for investments on brand new shuttle-less looms under ATUFS • A grant of 50% of the project cost (up to INR 2.5 crore (US$ 0.30 million) for creating a mini textile park
Uttar Pradesh	Uttar Pradesh Textile and Garmenting Policy 2022[95]	• Capital subsidy of 25% • A 100% exemption from electricity duty to new textile and garment units • Reimbursement of freight cost of container from unit to port up to 75% to encourage exports

5.2

Handicrafts

Overview

The Indian handicraft industry is a traditional sector employing more than seven million people. While most manufacturing units are located in rural areas and small towns, major clusters include cities like Surat, Bareilly, Varanasi, Agra, Hyderabad, Lucknow, Chennai, and Mumbai.[96] Tourism is a key enabler for the sector as visitors spend considerable amounts of money to purchase traditional local handicrafts as part of their immersive experience and as mementos to carry back home. This creates more opportunities and demand for local artisans and craftspeople to produce and sell their handicrafts more effectively. It has been the endeavour of the government to increase the market potential of the sector in cities/handicraft hubs across India and to aid exports.

The sector attracts female workers and entrepreneurs because of its low-capital setting wherein traditional skills rather than formal education become a key asset, offering livelihood security to women. Moreover, it provides an opportunity for women belonging to rural and/or remote villages/interior areas to convert their heritage crafts into viable enterprises using age-old skills, thereby preserving their intangible cultural heritage. As handicraft workers operate in small-scale, largely informal settings, community participation becomes pivotal for them to scale organically and network through SHGs, cooperatives, or clusters.

The figure below provides an overview of the sector.

Figure 2 **Sectoral Overview of the Indian Handicrafts Sector**

Handicrafts

- 56% of total artisans are female
- Market size to reach $7.8 billion (2032)
- Expected CAGR of 6.93%
- Total exports stood at $1.8 billion (FY24)
- Contributes 0.12% to GDP
- Market size of $4.2 billion (2023)
- Employs about 7 million people
- 744 clusters with over 35,000 products

National Schemes

Comprehensive Handicrafts Cluster Development Scheme[97, 98, 99]

- Aims to upgrade/create infrastructure facilities with market linkages within clusters
- Benefits include setting-up infrastructure, providing latest technology, skill training, capacity building, among other related benefits
- Establishment of a Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) implementing agency with prior experience in the handicraft sector
- Funds to the tune of 2% (max.) of project cost up to INR 5,00,000 (US$ 6,039.37) per project earmarked for evaluating the fund requirement as per the detailed project report
- A total of 3% of the project provided for setting up of a Project Monitoring Unit

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 160 crore (US$ 19.32 million)	• An amount of INR 85 crore (US$ 10.26 million) has been released between FY20 and FY24 • A total of 13 mega clusters have been formed	• Out of a total of 32.03 lakh artisans identified under the 'Pahchan Initiative', 20 lakh are female artisans • More employment opportunities

National Handicraft Development Programme[100, 101, 102]

- Aims to bring forth and bolster unique handicrafts of India also providing an impetus to handicraft exports
- Components include market support services, skill development, Hastshilp Vikas Yojana, DBTs, infrastructural support, and R&D
- Financial assistance ranges from INR 50 to INR 2 crore (US$ 0.6 to US$ 0.24 million) on as per the scheme component

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 837 crore (US$ 101.09 million)	• A total of 786 domestic & international marketing events and 674 skilling events have been organised under the aegis of the scheme • Financial Support to more than 1800 artisans in indigent circumstances • Interest subvention for more than 1300 artisans	• About 4.7 lakh women artisans have benefited under various components of the scheme

PM Vishwakarma Yojana[103, 104, 105]

- Aims to recognise artisans/craftspeople and their unique skills sets by providing them end-to-end support
- Provides artisans recognition by issuing them with certificates and IDs, and by onboarding them on e-commerce platforms like GeM
- Provision of basic training of 5-7 days and advanced training of 15 days or more, with a stipend of INR 500 per day
- A loan provision of up to INR 3,00,000 (US$ 3,623.62) is available in two tranches

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 13,000 crore (US$ 1.57 billion)	• More than 2.28 crore artisans have been enrolled in the scheme and 13.94 lakh beneficiaries have been successfully registered • Over 5 lakh candidates have been imparted with training	• Of the total number of artisans registered under the scheme, 5.42 lakh are women • Of the 5.03 lakh craftspeople who have been provided with training, 2.74 lakh are women • Of the 18 trades provided under the scheme, there are five trades – tailor, malakar (garland making), doll and toy maker, basket and related products maker, washing services – in which female enrolment is more than 50%

State Schemes

State	Scheme	Relevance
Chhattisgarh	State schemes governed by the Chhattisgarh Handicrafts Development Board[106]	• Training programme for up to two years (varying degree of skills) under Prashikskhan Yojna • Registration of artisans for enabling access to different government schemes under Shilpiyo Ka Panjiyan • Provision of INR 5,000 (US$ 60.39) for buying tools and INR 10,000 (US$ 120.78) for setting up a workshop under Avjar-karmshala Yojna
Gujarat	• Dattopant Thengadi Artisan Interest Subsidy Scheme[107] • Craft Business Development Scheme[108]	• Credit up to INR 1,00,000 (US$ 1,207.87) for machinery or working capital • Interest subsidy of 7% • Financial assistance of 70% on a project cost of up to INR 7 crore (US$ 0.84 million) for marketing, design studio, raw material, advertisement, export, and other related activities
Maharashtra	State schemes governed by the Maharashtra Small Scale Industries Development Corporation Ltd[109]	• Training of artisans for traditional handicrafts, new designs, and other training as per the demand • Organising exhibitions for sale and promotion of state handicrafts
Odisha	• Mukhyamantri Baristha Bunakar and Karigara Sahayata Yojana[110] • Institutional Training[111] • Marketing Assistance & Publicity • Modernisation and Technological Upgradation of Handicraft Industries	• Monthly assistance pay of INR 2,000/month (US$ 24.15) for weavers & ancillary workers and artisans (female aged 40-80 years & male age 50-80 years) if annual family income does not exceed INR 1,00,000 (US$ 1,207.87). Persons above 80 years of age will get INR 2,500/month (US$ 30.19) • Institutional training at state, district, and village level for up to one year with a monthly stipend of up to INR 2,000/month (US$ 24.15) • Marketing assistance including stall rent, transportation, travel, and related expenses covered up to INR 1,00,000 (US$ 1,207.87) • Margin money assistance of up to 30% with a ceiling of INR 12,00,000 (US$ 14,494.50) for technological up-gradation

State	Scheme	Relevance
Tamil Nadu	• State schemes governed by the Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Ltd[112, 113]	• Distribution of free tool kits worth INR 5,000 (US$ 60.39) • Conduct skill development training programmes for artisans with a stipend of INR 7,500/month (US$ 90.59) • Honouring craftspeople for their outstanding work and recognising them for their work
Uttar Pradesh	• Handicraft Marketing Incentive Scheme[114] • Handicrafts Skill Development Training Scheme • Chief Minister Handicrafts Pension Scheme	• Marketing incentive of up to INR 20,000 (US$ 241.57) for participating in fairs/exhibitions • Encouraging female participation in skill development programmes • Monthly pension of INR 500/month (US$ 6.03) for selected artisans (females aged above 55 years & males aged above 60 years) if annual family income does not exceed INR 1,00,000 (US$ 1,207.87)

5.3

Agro and Food Processing

Overview

India's food processing sector is one of the largest in the world, acting as a vital bridge between Indian farmers and consumers in both domestic and international markets. The sector comprises grains, sugar, edible oils, beverages, fisheries, fruits, vegetables, and dairy products. The Indian government has also recognised it as one of the growth impetus sectors allocating a PLI of about US$ 1.3 billion towards it. Moreover, given the growing ready-to-eat/ready-to-cook segment in India, this sector is poised to witness tremendous growth in the coming years.[115]

The sector attracts significant participation from female workers and entrepreneurs because it offers low-capital, high-value opportunities. Value addition in products such as pickles, spices, millet snacks, and ready-to-eat foods enable women to monetise local produce. Many women in rural areas have used this sector as a launchpad to build enterprises rooted in local agro ecological settings, scaling from kitchen-level operations to formal entities. Moreover, the sector leverages women's traditional roles in food preparation and preservation, transforming them into micro-enterprises that bridge the gap between informal skills and formal markets. With the rising demand for regional, organic, and clean-label foods, women-led MSMEs can tap into niche health and ethnic food markets.

Figure 3 **Sectoral Overview of the Indian Food Processing Sector**

Food Processing

- 24% of total workers are female
- Employs about 7 million people
- Projected CAGR of 7.3% (2022-27)
- Part of PLI scheme with an outlay of $1,3 billion
- Contributes 1% to GDP
- Market size of $866 billion (2022)
- 2nd largest egg and fish producer in the world
- 2nd largest producer of fruits & vegetables. in the world

National Schemes

Pradhan Mantri Kisan Sampada Yojana[116, 117, 118]

- Aims to build a resilient supply chain management system from farm gate to retail outlet
- Components include establishing integrated cold chains, promoting agro-processing clusters, creating food safety & quality assurance infrastructure, and investing in R&D among others
- Grants-in-aid available up to the limit of INR 50 crore (US$ 6.03 million), depending upon the project

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 10,600 crore (US$ 1.28 billion	• A total of 1608 projects have been approved, and a sum of INR 6,199 crore (US$ 748.76 million) has been disbursed • A total of 948 cold storages have been created under various components of the Yojana • As many as 1,78,781 employment opportunities have been generated between FY21 and FY24	• Provides opportunities for women entrepreneurs to equip themselves with modern industrial infrastructure • Enhances employment opportunities

PM Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises Scheme[119, 120, 121]

- Aims to enhance the competitiveness of micro-enterprises by promoting formalisation and by providing support to FPOs, SHGs, and related cooperatives
- Key components include support to micro enterprises, support to group categories, branding and marketing support, capacity building and R&D, among other
- Financial assistance of up to INR 3 crore (US$ 0.36 million) available as per the scheme component

Budget	Progress	Benefits for Women
• Outlay of INR 10,000 crore (US$ 1.20 billion)	• A total of 1,14,388 loans have been sanctioned under the credit linked subsidy • Setting up of 76 incubation centres has been approved, of which 15 have been established	• Creating opportunities for women entrepreneurs to transition from informal to formal enterprises

State Schemes

State	Scheme	Relevance
Chhattisgarh	Incentives for the sector included in state level MSME policy and industrial level scheme(s)	• Market assistance, training, assistance in land allotment, export facilitation, among other incentives included in the MSME policy • Full exemption on mandi tax under state industrial policy
Gujarat	Incentives for the sector included in state level MSME policy and industrial level scheme(s)	• Capital investment subsidy up to 25% with a ceiling of INR 35 lakh (US$ 42,275.63) • Interest subsidy of up to 7% with a ceiling of INR 35 lakh (US$ 42,275.63) • Quality certification (ISI/WHO/BIS/GMP/ etc), assistance of 50% on fee payable for certification and 50% on cost of testing up to INR 10 lakh (US$ 12,078.75) • Other benefits like ICT enablement, patent registration, energy conservation, power, etc may also be availed
Maharashtra	Chief Minister Agriculture and Food Processing Scheme[122]	• A provision of 30% subsidy for construction of factories up to INR 50 lakh (US$ 60,393.76)
Odisha	• Odisha Food Processing Policy 2022[123] • Mukhyamantri Krushi Udyog Yojana[124]	• Capital investment subsidy of 30% up to INR 3.5 crore (US$ 0.42 million) & 35% up to INR 4 crore for women (US$ 0.48 million) • Capital investment subsidy of 40% up to INR 50 lakh (US$ 60,393.76) & 50% up to INR 50 lakh for women (US$ 60,393.76) also available under Mukhyamantri Krushi Udyog Yojana
Tamil Nadu	• Tamil Nadu Food Processing Policy 2018[125]	• Interest subvention of 3% per annum (additional 2% for women) • Marketing assistance in the form of reimbursement of 50% of the total cost participation in trade fairs • Other incentives related to patent and exports applicable as per the MSME policy

State	Scheme	Relevance
Uttar Pradesh	• Uttar Pradesh Food Processing Policy (FPP) 2023 [126] • Uttar Pradesh Dairy Development and Milk Products Promotion Policy 2022[127] • Uttar Pradesh Poultry Development Policy 2022[128]	• Capital investment subsidy of up to 35% with a ceiling of INR 5 crore (US$ 0.60 million) • Exemption from mandi fees and cess for agricultural produce directly purchased/sold by farmers in the state • A subsidy of 50% on solar power utilities in rural areas and 90% for women entrepreneurs in the same category • Grant for transportation of milk produced in the state to ports of 25% that will be payable up to a maximum of INR 20 lakh (US$ 24,157.50) for 3 years • Patent and design registration reimbursement of up to 75% • A rebate of 100% on electricity duty for 10 years to poultry units established under the Poultry Development Policy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06

Challenges Faced by Women Entrepreneurs

A Multi-State Perspective

Women entrepreneurs continue to encounter a range of structural, financial, and socio-cultural barriers that hinder their participation and progress within the entrepreneurial ecosystem. While these constraints manifest differently across geographies, they often reflect deep-rooted disparities like limited institutional support, and restricted access to critical resources and networks. This section presents a synthesis of insights gathered through field-level stakeholder consultations. It seeks to articulate the practical realities and systemic challenges experienced by women entrepreneurs, as voiced by those closest to the ground. These insights serve to inform more context-responsive and inclusive strategies for advancing women's economic empowerment.

6.1 Challenges in Financial Inclusion for Women Entrepreneurs in India

The financial inclusion of women entrepreneurs in India remains a significant challenge, particularly in the context of accessing credit for MSMEs. According to a ICRIER survey report, 60.5% of MSME owners find it difficult to access financial services.[129] Moreover, around 48% of proprietors opine that it is even more difficult to obtain a loan if the owner is a woman, exhibiting a perception of gender bias. This is exacerbated by intertwined social and economic barriers like institutional unresponsiveness, bureaucratic challenges, hierarchical societal structures, and a lack of awareness. We examine the impact of these and other such barriers in the following section.

One of the most common attributes of female-run businesses is that they are not independently managed. In other words, the business is often registered in the name of some other family member, usually the spouse. Moreover, women's familial role acts as a key hindrance in their independently managing the business. Prevalent patriarchal norms also contribute to preventing women from independently owning an asset or business.

Another challenge is women's lack of awareness about government programmes, schemes, or initiatives, coupled with their lack of financial literacy. These two factors work as a double-edged sword inhibiting their access to financial services. Studies that have attempted to gauge the reasons for women's lack of access to credit have inferred that the lack of awareness is a critical disabler. On the other hand, the lack of financial literacy adds as a second-level barrier preventing access to financial services, even if they manage to gather information on these services. Lack of know-how about financial taxonomies adds to the perplexity

According to a ICRIER survey report,

60.5%

of MSME owners find it difficult to access financial services.

of the beneficiary. Therefore, it is not uncommon to see many entrepreneurs, especially women, resorting to borrowing money from the informal money lending ecosystem at a high rate of interest, with little or no paperwork. The gender gap in financial access is stark. According to the International Finance Corporation (IFC), 90% of women-owned businesses in India have never accessed formal credit.[130] Public sector banks allocate only 5.2% of their total MSME credit to women-owned enterprises—underscoring the systemic nature of this exclusion.[131] Critically, 43% of women, compared to 26% of men, report lack of credit access as the main reason for business discontinuation.[132] These numbers suggest that access to capital is not just a financial barrier—it is a structural inequality. Addressing this will require targeted financial literacy interventions and gender-intentional lending products that recognize the unique barriers women face.

Even when an entrepreneur overcomes the first two challenges, the third is often insurmountable; this is the challenge of institutional-bureaucratic barriers. Institutional barriers usually come into play because of the inability of the entrepreneur to produce the required documents (collateral, GST certificate, electricity bill, credit history etc.), often leading to either disqualification or procedural delays in the application process. For example, a study by IWWAGE has highlighted that women-led MSMEs face a 31% higher rejection rate for loans compared to those led by men. [133]

Further, according to a NITI Aayog report, women-led ventures experienced an average delay of

3-6 months

in loan disbursements.[134]

Such bureaucratic hassles, consequently, lead to a proliferation of intermediaries who charge a commission to get the entire process expedited for the intended beneficiaries whose need for funds is inevitably time-sensitive.

The unmet credit needs of women-led MSMEs are stark: according to an International Finance Corporation (IFC) study, women entrepreneurs in India require approximately INR 1.95 trillion (USD 23.73 billion) annually, yet formal Financial institutions fulfill only a fraction of this demand–supplying just INR 0.58 trillion (USD 6.93 billion).[135] This shortage exists within a broader context, as the Standing Committee on Finance estimates a nationwide (USD 243.4–304.2 billion), disproportionately affecting women entrepreneurs.Bridging this financial inclusion gap requires strengthening financial literacy programs and promoting inclusive lending policies that are accessible, transparent, and gender-responsive.

Initiatives like MUDRA loans and Stand-Up India have significantly improved credit access for women entrepreneurs by offering collateral-free loans. As of November 2023, over 1.51 crore women received MUDRA loans worth INR 87,718 crore (US$ 10.59 billion).[136] Stand-Up India sanctioned 1.44 lakh loans to women, totalling INR 33,152 crore (US$ 4 billion).[137]

According to an International Finance Corporation (IFC) study, women entrepreneurs in India require approximately

INR 1.95 trillion (USD 23.73 billion

annually, yet formal Financial institutions fulfill only a fraction of this demand–supplying just INR 0.58 trillion (USD 6.93 billion).

However, enabling financial inclusion for women entrepreneurs demands more than credit facilitation – it requires targeted interventions that challenge deep-rooted gender norms and systemic barriers. Encouraging asset ownership in women's names, strengthening outreach and financial literacy, adding a human touch to the banking sector, and making documentation requirements more accessible can significantly enhance access to finance. Government schemes must integrate gender-sensitive approaches, ensure last-mile delivery leveraging women-led SHGs, and create hand holding mechanisms.

6.2

Barriers to Women's Market Access in India: A Multi-State Analysis

Women entrepreneurs are integral to India's economic ecosystem, significantly contributing to job creation, innovation, and social progress. Their participation in the micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSME) sector is particularly noteworthy, as they account for approximately 20.5% of MSMEs in India. Despite their growing presence, women entrepreneurs face numerous structural challenges that hinder their ability to access markets effectively. These barriers often arise from deeply entrenched social norms, systemic gaps, and resource limitations that disproportionately affect women.

One of the most pressing challenges for women entrepreneurs is digital exclusion and e-commerce barriers. While the digital revolution has transformed market access globally, many women entrepreneurs in India struggle to leverage digital platforms for business expansion. Low digital literacy remains a significant barrier, as many women lack sufficient knowledge or skills to navigate e-commerce platforms effectively. This issue is especially pronounced in rural areas where exposure to technology is limited.

Women entrepreneurs in rural India face significant barriers to digital inclusion, with limited exposure to technology and low digital literacy hindering their ability to scale through e-commerce.

According to a NASSCOM Foundation and LEAD 2023 report, while 100% of women surveyed owned smartphones, only 58% used them for business. In the past five years, 83% of small businesses in India have moved online, with 65% earning up to half their revenue from online sales.

> Social media has played a key role, with
>
> **71% of women entrepreneurs**
>
> crediting it for business growth and 65% finding mentors through it.

These platforms help level the playing field for market access, while financial inclusion through digital banking and tech supports broader economic participation[138].

The financial burden associated with setting up online stores also disproportionately impacts small-scale women entrepreneurs who often cannot afford the costs associated with website development, payment gateway integration, and digital marketing. This lack of digital inclusion prevents women entrepreneurs from reaching wider audiences and competing effectively in the growing e-commerce sector.

Limited physical market access further exacerbates the difficulties faced by women entrepreneurs. Women in remote areas encounter higher costs and logistical challenges when trying to access urban markets. The lack of

transportation infrastructure forces many women to rely on local buyers or intermediaries who may take undue economic advantage of them. Due to cultural norms and family responsibilities that restrict mobility, many women entrepreneurs are confined to local marketplaces, which significantly reduces their customer base and market opportunities.

Infrastructural deficits present a significant barrier to market access for women entrepreneurs, particularly those involved in industries like agriculture or food production. Inadequate warehousing facilities are a major challenge, especially for businesses dealing with perishable goods such as agricultural produce or handmade food items. The lack of proper storage options forces these entrepreneurs to sell their products at lower prices, impacting their profitability. Furthermore, high transportation costs add another layer of difficulty. Moving goods from rural areas to urban markets is more expensive for women-led enterprises, as they often face logistical inefficiencies and rely on intermediaries, which raises costs. These infrastructural constraints reduce profit margins significantly, limiting the ability of women-led businesses to scale and reach wider markets. As a result, these challenges hinder their growth potential and broader market integration.

Social norms and cultural barriers also play a significant role in restricting women's market access. Cultural expectations often prevent women from traveling independently for business purposes. Family responsibilities such as caregiving, further limit their ability to attend trade fairs, exhibitions, or urban marketplaces where lucrative opportunities may exist. Additionally, women entrepreneurs face exclusion from male-dominated business networks that facilitate partnerships, collaborations, and mentorship opportunities. Without access to these networks, they struggle to establish connections that could help them expand their markets or improve operational efficiency.

Women entrepreneurs in India face numerous systemic challenges, particularly regarding access to professional networks and business associations. According to the Observer Research Foundation (ORF) report (2019), one of the major constraints is women's limited inclusion in professional and business networks, which restricts their ability to access knowledge-sharing platforms and market opportunities.[139] This lack of access often impedes business scalability and market integration. Supporting this, the National Sample Survey Office (NSSO) 73rd Round data reveals that only 20% of micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) in India are owned or operated by women. Further, an article notes that fewer than 13% of small businesses in India are run by women, underlining their underrepresentation in the entrepreneurial ecosystem. The Goldman Sachs 2023 report, emphasizes that women-owned businesses often struggle due to limited access to mentor networks, external capital, and formal support systems.[141] Collectively, these studies demonstrate that the exclusion of women entrepreneurs from business associations—while not always quantified in exact comparative terms to men—remains a substantial barrier to their growth, market expansion, and integration into the broader entrepreneurial ecosystem.

The Goldman Sachs 2023 report, emphasizes that women-owned businesses often struggle due to limited access to mentor networks, external capital, and formal support systems.

In conclusion, the barriers faced by women entrepreneurs in accessing markets are deeply rooted in gender-specific challenges that stem from social norms, infrastructural inadequacies, and limited resources. Addressing these barriers requires gender-responsive policies that prioritise women's needs within the entrepreneurial ecosystem. Improved digital literacy programs targeted at rural women, enhanced access to physical markets through better transportation infrastructure, affordable branding resources, and fostering inclusive business networks can significantly empower women entrepreneurs. By recognising these challenges as gender-specific issues requiring targeted solutions, policymakers can unlock the full potential of female entrepreneurs while driving economic growth and fostering greater inclusivity within India's markets.

6.3

Challenges to Skill Development for Women Entrepreneurs in India

Across India, women are increasingly stepping into entrepreneurship to support their families, contribute to their communities, and create new pathways to economic independence. Yet, despite their growing numbers, women entrepreneurs face persistent challenges in building the skills needed to start, sustain, and scale their businesses. Access to formal training, digital literacy, financial education, and mentorship remains limited. These barriers are not just personal setbacks; they reflect broader structural gaps that restrict India's ability to achieve inclusive and sustainable growth. Addressing the skill development needs of women entrepreneurs is not only a matter of equity–it is a strategic investment in the country's future.

One of the most significant barriers faced by women entrepreneurs is limited access to economic and institutional support, despite their presence in India's vast MSME sector. Of the 63 million MSMEs in India, only around 20% are women-owned, employing approximately 22 to 27 million people. This reflects a broader trend of limited formal workforce participation, with only 19% of India's 432 million working-age women engaged in formal and paid work.

The MSME sector, in particular, shows a stark gender imbalance in employment, with

76% of male employees

(84.46 million) and only

24% women employees

(26.49 million).

Interestingly, more women are employed in rural MSMEs (13.75 million) than in urban ones (12.74 million), suggesting that while rural areas may offer employment opportunities, challenges such as access to structured training and resources still limit women's entrepreneurial success.[142] These structural barriers, alongside limited representation and access to training, hinder the potential of women in contributing more significantly to India's entrepreneurial ecosystem.

Women-owned micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) in India face persistent and multifaceted financial challenges that hinder their growth and sustainability. A significant barrier is financial literacy, where many women entrepreneurs lack basic skills in budgeting, pricing, and expense management.

Even after participating in entrepreneurship or skilling programs, many women struggle to apply their knowledge in real-world contexts. Most training programs lack structured post-training support–especially mentorship–which is essential to translating skills into sustainable outcomes. Mentors can play a critical role in navigating regulations, identifying markets, or building business confidence. Without these linkages, women remain isolated from professional ecosystems that men are more likely to access via social capital. This missing middle–between training and market engagement–is a major point of attrition for women entrepreneurs.

Moreover, as discussed in previous sections, technological exclusion presents another formidable challenge for women entrepreneurs in India. Many are unfamiliar with digital platforms essential for marketing their products and scaling their businesses effectively. Poor internet connectivity in rural areas restricts participation in online training programs and e-commerce opportunities.In today's economy, digital tools are indispensable for growth–but women continue to face a significant digital gap. The GSMA's 2022 Mobile Gender Gap study found that women trail men by 14% points in mobile ownership and by 41 points in mobile internet use. This divide has persisted over time: between 2017 and 2020, male internet usage rose from 45% to 51%, while female usage stagnated at 30%.[143]

Socio-cultural norms present significant barriers with prescribed gender roles limiting female participation in skill training programs or professional networks. An International Labour Organisation (ILO) study found that Indian women spend an average of 297 minutes per day on unpaid care work, while men spend only 31 minutes. This indicates that women dedicate approximately 9.6 times more time to unpaid care work than men- an imbalance that restricts their availability for entrepreneurial activities.[144] Furthermore, gender biases within male-dominated business environments can make it difficult for women to engage fully in entrepreneurship.

The GoI has recognised these challenges and initiated several programs aimed at empowering women entrepreneurs. The Women Entrepreneurship Platform (WEP), launched by NITI Aayog in 2017, serves as an aggregator of information and services aimed at strengthening industry linkages and increasing awareness about existing programs for female entrepreneurs.[145]

In conclusion, while there has been progress in promoting women's entrepreneurship in India through government initiatives and support programs, significant challenges persist regarding skill development. Women entrepreneurs face barriers related to limited access to formal training programs, financial illiteracy, technological exclusion, insufficient mentorship opportunities, and socio-cultural constraints that hinder their ability to thrive.

Addressing these barriers requires a multi-faceted approach involving comprehensive skill development programs that integrate traditional skills with digital technologies; enhanced access to finance through targeted outreach; improved digital infrastructure; tailored financial literacy initiatives; and structured mentorship programmes designed specifically for female entrepreneurs. By implementing these strategies–backed by data-driven insights–India can make substantial strides toward achieving gender equality in entrepreneurship while unlocking the full potential of its female workforce. Empowering women through effective skill development is not just a matter of equity but also an economic imperative that can drive productivity and growth across sectors.

Between 2017 and 2020, male internet usage rose from45% to 51% while female usage stagnated at

30%.

6.4

Institutional and Policy Barriers for Women Entrepreneurs in India

Women entrepreneurs in India represent a growing segment of the entrepreneurial landscape. However, they continue to face institutional and policy barriers that restrict their ability to thrive. The expansion of the micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSME) sector has opened new avenues for female participation. Systemic challenges, ranging from procedural complexities to lack of financial inclusion, disproportionately affect women-led enterprises. These challenges are not just technical or procedural; they are deeply embedded in social norms, structural inequalities, and institutional inertia. Addressing these barriers is not merely a matter of economic development but also of gender justice and inclusive policy making.

A key barrier is the regulatory and compliance ecosystem. Registering and formalising a business remains cumbersome and inconsistent across states, which dissuades many women from entering the formal economy. Complex documentation requirements, procedural delays, and inadequate digital literacy are major deterrents.

India's global ranking in the Ease of Doing Business Index (2020) was 63; regulatory inefficiencies were specifically highlighted as a constraint for women entrepreneurs attempting to scale operations.[146]

Due to these barriers, many women-led enterprises rely on informal financing channels. A report by the ORF highlights that women entrepreneurs often depend on non-institutional sources, such as family, friends, or local lenders, which can come with unfavorable terms and restrict their ability to grow or formalize their businesses.[147]

Institutional support structures also reflect entrenched gender gaps. Women entrepreneurs have limited representation in formal business networks and decision-making platforms, which limits their access to mentorship, market linkages, and collaborative opportunities. Male-dominated business chambers and associations often overlook women-specific challenges in policy discourse.[148] Women are underrepresented in firm ownership and senior management roles, and they tend to be concentrated in lower-ranking positions. Specifically,

only 33 % of formal firms have female participation in ownership; only 14.7 % of formal firms have women in top manager positions.[149]

While specific data on women's representation in business chambers is limited, the existence of organizations like the Women's Indian Chamber of Commerce and Industry (WICCI) indicates efforts to address these disparities.[150]

Moreover, many government-run skill development programs do not integrate gender-responsive design. Legal and property rights constraints also pose major challenges. Property ownership among women remains significantly lower than among men, limiting their ability to offer collateral for business loans. Additionally, navigating the legal system is often time-consuming and expensive. The World Bank's "Women, Business and the Law 2023" report provides insights into the legal barriers faced by women entrepreneurs. It highlights that in many economies, women encounter legal obstacles that hinder their full economic participation, including in areas such as property rights, inheritance laws, and access to credit. These barriers can discourage women from pursuing formal legal action when disputes arise.[151]

Inconsistent implementation and weak monitoring of government policies further exacerbate the challenges faced by women entrepreneurs. Even when progressive policies are introduced, their impact is limited by poor execution at the state and local levels. Fragmented coordination among ministries and agencies often leads to duplication of efforts and resource inefficiencies. The World Economic Forum's (WEF, 2023) Gender Gap Index identified inconsistent policy implementation as a major factor hindering economic empowerment.[152]

In conclusion, women entrepreneurs in India face a complex interplay of institutional and policy-level barriers that limit their full participation in the economy. These challenges are deeply gendered and require targeted, gender-responsive interventions. Simplifying regulatory processes, improving access to formal finance, enhancing institutional representation, and strengthening the implementation of women-specific policies are essential steps toward enabling an inclusive entrepreneurial ecosystem. Addressing these barriers with urgency and sensitivity will not only empower women entrepreneurs but also catalyse broader economic growth and social transformation across India.

India's global ranking in the Ease of Doing Business Index (2020) was 63; regulatory inefficiencies were specifically highlighted as a constraint for women entrepreneurs attempting to scale operations.

07

Recommendations

7.1

Financial Inclusion

01 Strengthening of the participation of women as banking agents and ombudsmen

Evidence suggests that women are more likely to avail financial services if a female banker or agent is available to help them, yet female banking correspondents (BCs) make up only 14% of the BC workforce.[153-154] Financial institutions should recruit and train more women BCs, adopt gender-sensitive workplace policies, and enforce safety measures to invite more women to the profession. State-level mandates must set inclusion targets and offer performance-based incentives for institutions meeting gender diversity goals. Additionally, appointing female ombudsmen within financial institutions can provide a trusted channel for grievance redressal, address gender-specific challenges faced by women agents and clients, and promote a more inclusive and gender-responsive banking environment.

02 Expansion of access to credit through digital lending and collateral-free products

Most female entrepreneurs usually have to depend on their own savings, loans from family and friends, or micro-loans to finance their business needs.[155-156] Digital lending platforms should offer collateral-free, low-documentation credit. Government-backed schemes such as the Credit Guarantee Fund Trust for Micro and Small Enterprises (CGTMSE)[157] and MUDRA[158] could increase loan ceilings and improve outreach to women entrepreneurs.

(As of March 2023, over 41 crore loans amounting to INR 23.2 lakh crore (US$ 280.22 billion) have been sanctioned under MUDRA, with approximately 68% of loans going to women. Under CGTMSE, INR 56,172 crore (US$ 6.78 billion) worth of guarantees were approved for women-owned MSMEs in FY 2022–23).[159]

03 Leveraging of self-help groups (SHGs) and community credit networks

With more than 90 million women engaged through the National Rural Livelihoods Mission,[160-161] SHGs are a powerful tool for financial inclusion. Models like Telangana's Stree Nidhi and Gujarat's Sakhi Mandals show that SHGs can provide fast, flexible credit. Microfinance institutions, self-help groups, and joint liability groups make it easier for women to access credit, than as an individual applicant. A joint credit history and community accountability mechanisms can improve their commercial viability as borrowers. Strengthening SHG-bank linkages, digitising credit flows, and adding business and financial literacy training can formalise SHGs as microfinance intermediaries and reduce reliance on informal lenders.

04 Adoption of gender-responsive, alternative credit-scoring models

Traditional methods of assessing creditworthiness, which rely on property rights, formal income, and borrowing history as common inputs to a credit score, often exclude potentially credit-worthy women due to gender disparities in asset ownership and lack of participation in formal financial systems. A study by Innovation for Poverty Action in the Dominican Republic found that alternative credit-scoring approaches using psychometrics and mobile phone usage patterns approved one-third more women for loans than traditional assessments. The intervention used mobile call detail records (CDR) and historical bill payment data to generate gender-responsive credit scores. Fintechs can also play a pivotal role in expanding women's access to credit by embedding tailored credit solutions directly into digital payment platforms and transactional touchpoints used by women-led micro-businesses. As adoption of digital payments increases across the MSME ecosystem, fintechs are intuitively leveraging real-time cash flow and transaction data to assess creditworthiness, bypassing traditional barriers like lack of collateral or formal credit histories.[163]

05 Integrating financial services with women's existing digital touchpoints to improve uptake

Due to limited digital financial literacy and time poverty, women entrepreneurs are relatively more unlikely than men to adopt standalone financial products. To address this, financial inclusion efforts should be coupled with non-financial services on platforms women already use, such as e-commerce and social commerce. Embedding tools like digital payments or credit within these familiar digital ecosystems increases the likelihood of adoption among women entrepreneurs and their business networks. For instance, the National Payments Council of India (NPCI), under the Reserve Bank of India, is collaborating with e-commerce platforms to integrate payment solutions directly into the workflows of women-led enterprises, enabling more seamless access to finance. The NPCI, in collaboration with Women's World Banking, has launched the "UPI for Her" initiative to enhance women's participation in digital payments. This program partners with fintech companies like MobiKwik, PhonePe, and SpiceMoney to integrate payment solutions directly into platforms used by women-led enterprises. By generating digital transaction records, this initiative can mitigate gender gaps in bank account usage and help women build a credit history.[165]

7.2

Market Access

01 **Building of e-commerce and digital market competence through co-created training sessions by government bodies and e-commerce platforms**

By mitigating geographical barriers, e-commerce offers women entrepreneurs across India the opportunity to tap into wider markets. Although India has more than 22 million women-owned businesses, only 13% participate in e-commerce. There is ample headroom for women entrepreneurs to grow provided they are trained in digital marketing, logistics, and are onboarded on platforms like GeM and ONDC on a priority basis. Simplifying registration processes and subsidising cataloguing/logistics for women can improve competitiveness. Partnerships between industry and government for skilling programs in this domain would help enhance curriculum design and delivery to ensure greater relevance and efficiency.

02 **Improvement of market access through public procurement platforms**

Under the Womaniya initiative, GeM has created specific product categories such as handicrafts and handloom, accessories, jute and coir products, bamboo products, organic foods, spices, home décor, and office furnishings to facilitate the listing and procurement of products made by women entrepreneurs. This categorisation streamlines the process for government buyers to identify and procure products from women-led enterprises. Yet, despite a mandated 3% public procurement quota, women-led MSMEs represent just 8% of sellers on the GeM portal.[166-167] The platform must simplify onboarding, institutionalise vendor support, and provide language-accessible helpdesks. Outreach should prioritise SHGs and women entrepreneurs, with targeted awareness campaigns and technical support.

03 Bridging of the private procurement gap through information dissemination on procurement standards and financial incentives

WMSME suppliers often struggle with insufficient information about corporate purchasing practices, limited understanding of procurement standards, and inadequate access to the financing needed to compete for larger contracts. On the other hand, corporate buyers face challenges in identifying eligible women-owned businesses due to limited access to reliable databases. They also lack clarity on how to make their supplier onboarding processes more inclusive and are often unaware of best practices to better support the participation of women-owned MSMEs.[168] Targeted awareness programs among corporate buyers and WMSMEs, alongside tax incentives or subsidies to corporations that actively collaborate with women entrepreneurs, can help bridge these gaps. To drive more inclusive sourcing, companies must introduce KPIs like spend on women-owned MSMEs and engage in targeted outreach through women's business associations. Additionally, annual matchmaking events between corporate procurement teams and potential women-owned suppliers can help expand their supplier base.

04 Promotion of affordable production technology in traditional sectors towards quality enhancement

A key concern raised by procurement teams regarding women-owned MSMEs is their inconsistent adherence to quality standards, which often becomes a barrier to onboarding them as suppliers. Women entrepreneurs in sectors such as textiles, handicrafts, and food processing lack access to mechanisation and digital tools. Government and private partnerships must popularise sector-specific, low-cost technologies and provide training through NGOs or local agencies. Schemes such as CGTMSE and "Digital India" should

explicitly earmark funds for tech adoption. The outcome of these efforts would be improved product quality standards, which in turn can significantly enhance access to both domestic and international markets.

7.2

Skill Development

01 Promotion of digital and financial literacy using community-based models

Digital literacy is a major barrier to financial inclusion. Rural women are less likely than men to use mobile internet.[169-170] Scalable solutions, such as the "Digital Didi" model–where trained SHG members deliver door-to-door literacy training–should be implemented nationally. These efforts must be supported through subsidised smartphone provision and expansion of programs like PMGDISHA[171] and Udyam Sakhi, with a focus on last-mile connectivity.

02 Implementation of inclusive and culturally appropriate capacity-building initiatives

Entrepreneurial training programs must account for barriers faced by women, including low literacy and time poverty. Initiatives should integrate indigenous knowledge via participatory tools such as PRA techniques, employ mobile and interactive formats for flexibility, and engage local women trainers as peer educators. The Intel-Udyogini School of Entrepreneurship serves as a scalable model for this approach and should be expanded through public-private partnerships.[172]

03 Evolving from skill development to holistic entrepreneurship development support

Skilling programs for women entrepreneurs must evolve from narrow technical training to holistic entrepreneurship development, integrating core business skills (financial/digital literacy, marketing, e-commerce, etc.) with life skills and motivation training. The curriculum should stay aligned with market needs, while enabling active participation through family engagement, lost wage compensation, and childcare support to foster long-term success.

04 Provision of mentorship and post-training support in sustaining entrepreneurial outcomes

Mentorship and post-training support are critical to preventing post-training drop-offs and sustaining entrepreneurial outcomes. Digital platforms like the NITI Aayog Women Entrepreneurship Platform represent a strong effort in this direction, and highlight the importance of digital access.

7.2

Policy and Institutional Reform

01 Need for urgent implementation of gender-disaggregated data collection exercises for the MSME sector

The lack of updated, gender-disaggregated data significantly hampers policymakers' ability to identify the pain points of or design targeted interventions for WMSMEs. The most recent comprehensive MSME data in India dates back to the 73rd round of the National Sample Survey (NSS) in 2015-16, which provides outdated information on the needs and challenges of MSME businesses. Moreover, available data is not disaggregated by gender. To address this, conducting periodic gender-disaggregated MSME surveys is essential for gathering the data needed to guide more effective, targeted programs. Research from global contexts, like the UN Women's Gender Data Gaps Report, shows that regular gender-specific data collection allows for better-targeted interventions.[173] There is a pressing need to restart official data collection exercises, such as the All-India MSME Census, with a gender-disaggregated focus to create a baseline for informed interventions. Additionally, schemes should implement regular monitoring and reporting mechanisms, such as the PM Vishwakarma Yojana's MIS infrastructure, which tracks training data on the NSDC portal, offering a useful model for all initiatives.

02 Support of formalisation through awareness and registration assistance for the Udyam portal, GST filing, and women entrepreneurship schemes

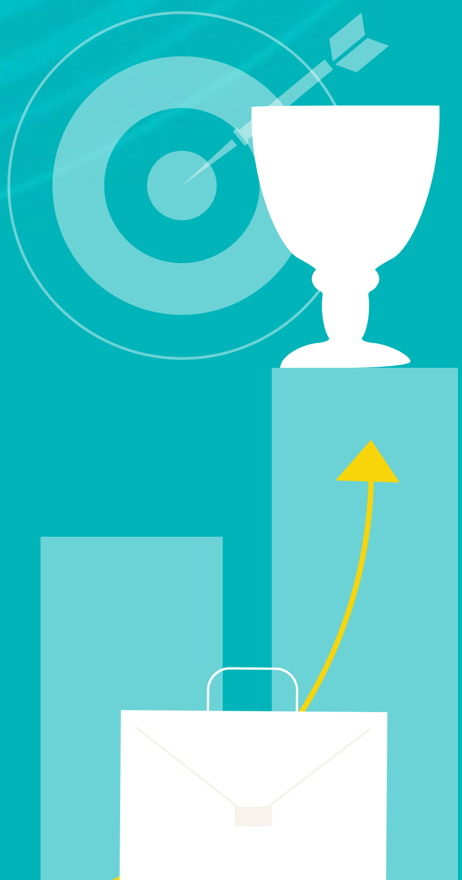
Many women-led businesses are restricted to the informal sector due to unfamiliarity with registration procedures. Regular cluster-based camps in high-MSME zones should be organised to assist with Udyam registration, GST filing, and scheme enrolments. Complementary mass awareness campaigns–drawing from the Swachh Bharat model–can promote understanding of the long-term benefits of formalisation, including access to subsidies, credit, and procurement.[174]

03 Institutionalisation of female representation in decision-making bodies, from the panchayat level to the central government level

To ensure inclusive policy making, women must be represented in decision-making bodies. Increased representation for women should be instituted in MSME advisory boards, credit review panels, and scheme monitoring committees. This structural reform will ensure that the perspectives and priorities of women entrepreneurs are systematically integrated into the policy ecosystem.

08

Success Stories



Six women entrepreneurs from the six states generously shared their valuable time with us for an interview, offering an in-depth look into their unique entrepreneurial journeys and the challenges they faced along the way. Their success stories highlight the key factors driving women's entrepreneurship and serve as a source of inspiration for us all.

Ms. Raziya Shaikh
Chhattisgarh

Introduction

Ms. Raziya Shaikh, a microbiologist, food consultant, and entrepreneur from Bastar, an underdeveloped district in the state of Chhattisgarh. She is the founder of Bastar Food Firm, established in 2019, which specialises in manufacturing nutritious food products sourced from indigenous forest produce–most notably Mahua. Her enterprise also provides vocational training in food technology to students, women's self-help groups, and youth across the state, contributing to economic empowerment and inclusive growth. What began as a personal initiative to tackle local unemployment has evolved into an enterprise that employs numerous tribal women in southern Chhattisgarh, promoting financial independence and redefining the socio-economic landscape of the region Bastar.

What is special about Ms Shaikh and her business?

Inspired by the diligence and self-sufficiency of street vendors in comparison to employees at MNCs, Ms. Shaikh leveraged her tribal locality as a prime asset, even though many employers traditionally viewed it as a limitation. Harnessing the symbiotic relationship between the forests and Bastar's inhabitants, she embarked on a journey to create opportunities, not just for herself but also the tribal communities of the region. After three years of meticulous groundwork with an NGO to understand the tribal lifestyle and business dynamics in her state, Ms. Shaikh initiated her venture with INR 200 and now boasts an annual turnover of approximately INR 20 lakh per annum. The hallmark of Ms. Shaikh's enterprise is its fusion of tribal culture and cuisine; notably, being the sole registered food manufacturer of Mahua products. Collaborating with the UK-based company ōForest, Bastar Food Firm aids in the procurement of Mahua - known for its nutritional benefits - from Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh. Ms. Shaikh has also worked with the Chhattisgarh Tribal Department to train and empower tribal women in business and forest-based product ventures.

Business Financing

How has she financed her business thus far?

Despite facing challenges in obtaining finance due to the negative social connotations associated with Mahua (her primary raw material), Ms. Shaikh utilised her earnings from her consulting and training endeavours to kickstart her food manufacturing firm. Recognising the need for strategic investments, she ingeniously sold the original Mahua Ladoo recipe to the Chhattisgarh Forest Department, thereby acquiring the requisite capital for scaling up her enterprise. Subsequently, via her role as a trainer for tribal communities, she garnered further capital to reinvest in her business. Ms. Shaikh advocates risk-taking and self-belief, asserting that entrepreneurial ventures require continuous reinvestment and resilience for consistent growth.

Did she avail of any schemes for her business?

Ms. Shaikh capitalised on the benefits offered by the Pradhan Mantri Formalisation of Micro Food Processing Enterprises Scheme (PMFME), securing approximately INR 50 lakh (about US$ 60,393.76). This funding facilitated the procurement of additional machinery, packaging materials, and the expansion of her product line, thus enabling her to segue into various e-commerce platforms and physical retail outlets. The policy has several provisions, including a credit linked capital subsidy of 35%, seed capital, capacity building training, and a 50% financial grant for marketing and branding. Such government schemes have played a pivotal role in empowering small-scale entrepreneurs like Ms. Shaikh, providing access to finance and infrastructure essential for business growth. Ms. Shaikh also suggests that there should be additional tax exemptions for women entrepreneurs.

Training and Education

Did Ms. Shaikh have any training to run her business?

Ms. Shaikh underwent a month-long training program in the USA, courtesy of a prestigious fellowship by the Motwani Jadeja Foundation. This comprehensive training equipped her with essential skills in resource allocation, investment strategies, operational efficiency, and business development. Ms. Shaikh emphasises the importance of staying abreast of industry innovations beyond regional boundaries, exemplified by her annual participation in expositions, conferences, and training sessions across metropolitan cities in India, such as Delhi, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Coimbatore, and Pune.

What kind of training does she recommend to support other women in becoming entrepreneurs?

Ms. Shaikh advocates for tailored training programmes to empower women entrepreneurs, particularly those from marginalised backgrounds. She emphasises the necessity of incorporating modules on licensing procedures, current government policies, and financial literacy to maximise the take-up of benefits from available schemes. Moreover, she underlines the stark contrast in access to entrepreneurial training for urban residents and tribal people, particularly since the latter often lack even basic opportunities for primary education. She advocates for business training integration into school curricula to foster a conducive environment for aspiring women entrepreneurs. By equipping women with the requisite skills and knowledge, policy interventions can effectively support women's entrepreneurial endeavours, driving inclusive economic growth and societal development.

Accessing Markets

How has Ms. Shaikh built and maintained her market reach?

Ms. Shaikh strategically utilises both online and offline channels to amplify her product's market presence. Moreover, she leverages co-branding techniques to bolster her business's visibility. Collaborations have emerged as a pivotal avenue for nurturing her B2B relationships over time. Notably, Ms. Shaikh prioritises the recognition and visibility of her staff alongside the brand, facilitating their participation in various expositions nationwide. Sales analysis plays a crucial role in informing her market expansion strategies. Additionally, she underscores the importance of aligning with seasonal availability and product trends to effectively meet customer demand. Over the years, she has ensured that her business recognises different segments of society and caters to each one of them differently, through customised food products and packaging, such as cartoon-printed biscuit packaging for children.

Policy and Institutional Support

What has been Ms. Shaikh's experience with the government and its regulations?

Ms. Shaikh appreciates the government for having made exceptional efforts in drafting policies for women entrepreneurs, but she adds that there is an evident lack of penetration of policy benefits to the grassroots level. Regular transfers of concerned officers at the district level brings instability in the implementation process, which is left at the discretion of the officers. This disruption occurs every two years, creating an additional barrier for women entrepreneurs. She also highlights the impact of political changes on women entrepreneurs, wherein the state government strongly influences the mechanisms facilitating her journey. When there is greater cohesion between governance bodies at the central and state level, then the implementation of central policies is better, directly translating into higher female workforce participation, more self-help groups, and other related facilities.

What regulatory changes does she suggest?

Ms. Shaikh points to three different categories of women entrepreneurs: first, those who want to be entrepreneurs, second, those who started a few years ago or are first-generation entrepreneurs, and third, those who have inherited family businesses or have been running their own enterprise for decades. These categories have different demands and needs for assistance. All of them should be included in the deliberation process of policy formulation, so that everyone's concerns can be addressed in a systematic and participatory manner. She also strongly recommends the simplification of government regulations, including tax filing. Small entrepreneurs cannot always afford the professional services of a chartered accountant for filing taxes multiple times a year. Licensing procedures also need to be made simpler and cheaper. Some industries, like food manufacturing, require a lot of licensing, which need to be renewed time and again, adding to the burden of an entrepreneur.

Ms. Shaikh also specifies that there is a lack of knowledge around the available government schemes. She mentions the need for a streamlined mechanism to spread awareness of the government provisions for women entrepreneurs. For this, she suggests that outside every government office or relevant officer's cabin, information regarding such schemes should be advertised, links and documents should be made available at help desks, and every district should organise awareness sessions solely to disseminate policy information, including details on the allocated funds. Transparency and accountability are the key elements for any policy intervention. She also expresses that most of the benefits of various schemes and policies do not extend beyond the boundaries of the capital city of a state. Since almost every government body in the state of Chhattisgarh is situated in Raipur, it becomes harder for entrepreneurs and start-ups outside the city to avail the benefits and facilities designed for them.

Should there be training for complying with government regulations?

Ms. Shaikh makes it clear that training is the most important provision to be made for women entrepreneurs. One-roof training centres, such as the WE HUB in Hyderabad, should be introduced in each state, specially designed for women entrepreneurs. These serve as a facilitation centre for all kinds of women entrepreneurs, from those who are just starting their business to those who have well established international connections. Business networking can be made possible by such centres, which can facilitate communication and dreams.

Women-Specific Entrepreneurial Challenges

What are the critical challenges, in Ms Shaikh's view, faced by women entrepreneurs?

Ms. Shaikh says that in her experience women are better entrepreneurs than their male counterparts yet they end up missing out on business opportunities outside their area of residence. She shares that she herself was often rejected due to her residence in the politically unstable region of Bastar. She further explained that a woman entrepreneur, owing to her familial responsibilities, cannot travel for even a day or two to other cities and towns to expand her business. Travelling is one of the biggest challenges specific to women entrepreneurs. She notes that online hatred and cybercrime against working women must also be listed as threats to their business.

Is there a message Ms. Shaikh would like to share with other women entrepreneurs?

Ms. Shaikh says a woman entrepreneur only needs space, respect, and family support to become an unstoppable force. She also appreciates the changing mentality of men these days, who are accepting and respecting of women venturing into entrepreneurial careers. Women should show their capabilities and strength to prevent other people in society from trying to overpower them. She says that it is important to remember that everyone who has taken birth has a purpose to serve. She says,

"Be patient, be calm, and serve your purpose. Look after yourself. You cannot take anything with you when you die, so make sure that you leave behind something meaningful for future generations to admire, look up to, and take inspiration from."

Dr. Prunel Khawani
Gujarat

Introduction

Dr. Prunel Khawani is the founder of the label Desiii, which celebrates Indian heritage through exquisite craftsmanship and promotes sustainable fashion. She is also an assistant professor at AURO University, a fashion and textile consultant, and a Ph.D mentor. With an interest in technical studies and a zeal for the arts, Dr. Khawani became an engineer and overcame social and geographical constraints to complete a Fashion Styling certificate course in London, before pursuing a Ph.D. in Indian Traditional Textiles (Engineering). Prior to starting label Desiii, she worked passionately to build her other label 'Dream Attire' for 15 years. She has established her own fashion boutique and showcased her talent through more than 50 exhibitions. She also has experience as a fabric designer, particularly working with dobby and jacquard looms. Reflecting on balancing life, society, expectations, and her wishes, Dr. Khawani shared her entrepreneurial journey with us.

What is special about Dr. Khawani and her business?

Dr. Khawani credits her love for Indian heritage and traditional textiles as the key motivating factor which pushed her to explore this field further and start her own business. She has also been recognised for her expertise in fashion and textile consulting, with a feature in the Gujarati daily newspaper Divya Bhaskar. Leveraging her experience in Neuro-Linguistic Programming (NLP), she intertwines NLP and design for growth to conduct unique mentorship sessions for corporates, student groups, and professionals. She believes that she has found her purpose through business by serving her clients' biggest demand: affordable and high-quality fashion.

Business Financing

How has Dr. Khawani financed her business so far? Did she avail of any schemes for her business?

Dr. Khawani started with her family's financial support, but over the years, she has been able to self-finance her business through regular operational revenue. While Dr. Khawani has yet to explore government schemes or aid, she emphasises the importance of such initiatives for women-owned businesses. Recognising that financial assistance is crucial, she also advocates for comprehensive support encompassing training, mentorship, access to markets, and regulatory guidance tailored specifically for women entrepreneurs. She believes there is a lack of awareness about government-led programs among women entrepreneurs and suggests improving communication channels to promote existing schemes and policies effectively.

Training and Education

Did Dr. Khawani have any training to run her business?

While Dr. Khawani did not receive any business training or related education, she has been acquainted with business know-how through her friends, family, and personal experiences. She points out that even though she was not well-versed with business nuances, she was a master of materials and textiles, helping her establish her brand. She then deepened this interest through thorough research in handloom and natural dyes, adding to her entrepreneurial resilience.

What kind of training does she suggest for assisting other women entrepreneurs?

According to Dr. Khawani, training for women entrepreneurs is essential, especially to break the patriarchal norms that teach Indian women that running a business can only be a hobby and will always be secondary to their family role of providing for their children and husband. She emphasises how callous attitudes are detrimental to the success of a business. In addition to practical business training, she underscores the importance of policies and initiatives specifically tailored to address the unique challenges faced by women entrepreneurs. These could include mentorship programs, networking opportunities, and workshops on financial literacy and business management.

Accessing Markets

Over the last couple of years, how has Dr. Khawani built and maintained her market reach?

Dr. Khawani opted for an unconventional method to facilitate market connections. With no marketing, she relied solely on exhibitions to display her business's promising work. She coupled this with exceptional after-sales services, providing free alterations for her customers even after six months of purchase. Word of mouth also helped her to grow her market reach and gain new customers. Moreover, Dr. Khawani emphasises that policies aimed at promoting women-owned businesses should include initiatives to help them showcase their products to facilitate their access to the market. By leveraging such opportunities, women entrepreneurs can expand their customer base and effectively establish themselves in the marketplace.

Policy and Institutional Support

What has been Dr. Khawani's experience with the government and the regulatory framework? What regulatory changes does she suggest?

Dr. Khawani expresses how GST registration with the government is not just easy but also necessary, allowing entrepreneurs to diversify their supply chain by listing their products on e-commerce platforms. She also suggests that the government needs to provide more than just financial aid. The government should intervene in areas like business strategy, consultation, marketing, etc. to better assist entrepreneurs in growing their business. She proposes a government-backed 'Shark Tank' model for the same. Moreover, the government needs to have better means of communication to advertise the available schemes and policies. Dr. Khawani believes that by streamlining regulatory processes and offering comprehensive support services, the government can create a more conducive environment for women entrepreneurs to thrive.

Women-Specific Entrepreneurial Challenges

What other challenges does Dr. Khawani think women entrepreneurs face over their male counterparts?
Dr. Khawani indicates that women entrepreneurship is a rare and exceptional phenomenon, as women are taught to prioritise family over everything, including business, right from their childhood. Social stigma and familial expectations are the strongest factors pulling them away from entrepreneurship, with emotional baggage compromising their entrepreneurial journeys. Lack of financial literacy is also a major contributing factor to women's additional struggles as entrepreneurs. She notes that financial literacy is as important for women as their voting rights. She envisions an equal distribution of chores and earning responsibilities, without gendered labelling of roles. She suggests that financial literacy should be taught as a separate subject in schools for all children.

Message for Other Women Entrepreneurs

What would Dr. Khawani like to say to other women entrepreneurs?
Dr. Khawani wants women entrepreneurs to know that the world is filled with opportunities, and they must explore what ignites their passion and seize related opportunities. She also asserts that the biggest strength of any woman entrepreneur is her commitment. If they can put in their relentless conviction and dedication towards their business, surpassing social divisions, then the sky's the limit. She says,

"Women should find an equilibrium between their personal and professional lives, as business, too, is like a baby and should be nurtured similarly."

Ms. Stuti Lal
Uttar Pradesh

Introduction

Ms. Stuti Lal, an academic, was pushed towards entrepreneurial ventures as the result of what she calls a "paradigm shift" in her views on life. The pandemic struck right after her prolonged recovery from an accident, which made her explore new opportunities for work. On her journey from being an accomplished assistant professor of Computer Science to becoming an award-winning entrepreneur with government recognition, as well as a mentor at 'Womennovator' (a Global Incubator for Women), Ms. Lal shares interesting insights into a patriarchal business world rife with challenges.

What is special about Ms. Lal and her business?

During the COVID-19 pandemic, Ms. Lal and her father built a business keeping citizens' health concerns at the forefront. The government was promoting kaadha (a herbal decongestant and immunity-builder drink) to combat COVID-19. But there was no prescribed staple composition or ingredient list, so people were curious as to which herbs blend would provide optimum health benefits. To cater to this rising demand for kaadha, Ms. Lal and her father started distributing powdered herb mixes for lung care and immunity-boosting during COVID-19. Later, the range was expanded to treat different lifestyle ailments like diabetes, stress, anxiety, and muscular pains. These blends were designed to supplement post-COVID care.

Business Financing

How has Ms. Lal financed her business so far? Did she avail of any scheme(s) for her business?

Ms. Lal's enterprise is a start-up financed by the rolling of funds. Any profit was re-invested to grow the business further. The venture started with less than ten thousand rupees and can now sustain itself solely with its profit. She says that in India, finance is given primary importance when starting a business, but the first step should be to find a problem statement to cater to with a sustainable solution. Ms. Lal applied for different avenues of financial assistance in the form of government grants, including those offered by StartIn UP and Ministry of Agriculture, but was rejected each time, without clarity on the reasons for rejection. She believes she faced gender discrimination, suspecting that representatives did not engage with her project as seriously as they would have if she were a man. She investigated the reasons for her rejection from the Biotechnology Ignition Grant Scheme for new product development and found out that her research project was evaluated by experts from fields that were irrelevant to her product category. She did not let these hurdles stop her, and learnt that women must always voice their opinion, otherwise they will time and again be denied what they want.

Training and Education

Did Ms. Lal have any training to run her business?

Ms. Lal has undertaken several training sessions to understand business needs. Coming from a non-business background, she considers her various training sessions as milestones in her journey. The first of them, she recalls, was the 'Entrepreneurship Development Program' at IIM Kashipur, followed by the 'Accelerator Program' by the Wadhwani Foundation, California. They later verified Ms. Lal's business model and provided an international certification to the venture as a 'business with potential.' These training sessions taught her the importance of partnerships and how to enter the market for herbal drinks with validations of different kinds for greater credibility. She signed an MoU with CSIR to validate the products and their 'therapeutic' benefits, and another one with the Pharmacology department of Kumaun University, Nainital, to further validate the products on animal models. She credits these training sessions with strengthening her confidence in the potential of her business model.

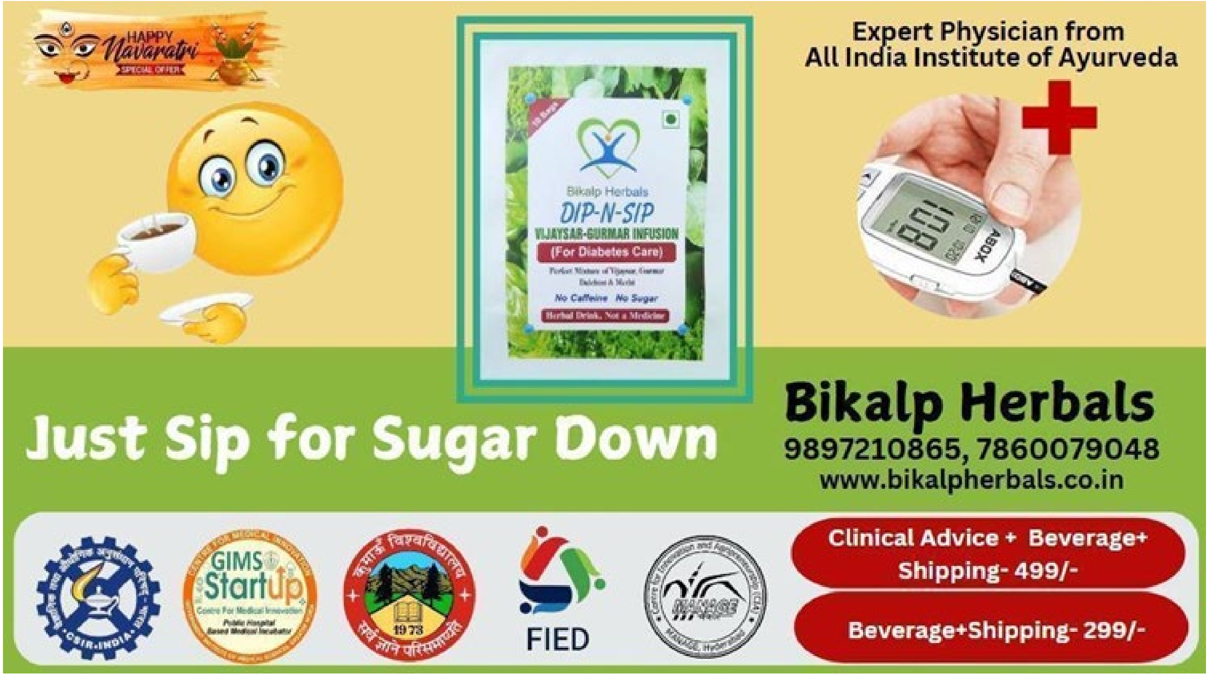
What kind of training does she suggest there be for assisting other women entrepreneurs?

Ms. Lal suggests that women should be given entrepreneurial training starting at the school level to enable them to surpass the biases of the society. She adds that different kinds of courses with components of entrepreneurship and strategic management ought to be made available for women, to make them more assertive, decisive, and self-reliant. Sometimes the traditional MBA is not enough to equip entrepreneurs with all the skills and knowledge required to start and run a business successfully, thus, a specialised MBA for startups is essential today. She also points to the fact that it is important for an entrepreneur to cater to either a problem, a particular demand, or a gap in the market. In the absence of these, the entrepreneur is simply introducing a wasteful product in an oversaturated market. To avoid this, access to business management experts and consultants is required. They can help an entrepreneur understand the market, its requirements, and ways to enter it in the most sustainable manner.

Accessing Markets

Over the last couple of years, how has Ms. Lal built and maintained her market reach?

Ms. Lal's market connect was established on her reputation, garnered by distributing herbal mixes among friends and family to help them during the pandemic. Word of mouth and referrals worked as the best marketing strategy for her, as people noticed the positive health difference made through her drinks. Ms. Lal also remained dynamic with her product range, identifying different ailments that were on the rise due to the pandemic and adding new herbal mixes to target each one of them. Another factor that helped Ms. Lal grow her market has been her active participation in start-up exhibitions and trade fairs. She has displayed her products and explained their benefits to customers in-person through many such events. Today Ms. Lal has a strong customer base, with over 1,000 regular customers.



Policy and Institutional Support

What has been Ms. Lal's experience with the government and the regulatory framework?

Ms. Lal believes that government regulation at the intersection of medicinal plants and food products requires serious revamping. At present, this overlap is posing issues for entrepreneurs selling products which qualify both as a food product and a medicinal plant, as they require different labels and types of testing for the same product. Conflicting guidelines for functional food and AYUSH medicines poses regulatory challenges and constant delays at the product development stage. She adds that India should adopt and be at par with international regulatory standards in this domain so that the process is streamlined for Indian entrepreneurs in the field. She also highlights that despite government provisions to promote women entrepreneurs, personal biases among related personnel like grant judges, trainers, etc. continue to be pain points.

What regulatory changes does she suggest?

She points to the necessity of training the trainers or educators empanelled in government training programmes. Training must focus on enabling them to overcome their personal value-based judgements and focus on entrepreneurship development outcomes. Key personnel themselves require entrepreneurship training so that they understand the nuances of starting a business to help beneficiaries more effectively. At times, trainers possess specialised knowledge of one field but not others, rendering entrepreneurs under their guidance helpless. The government must introduce integrated platforms and windows, especially for businesses that fall under multiple purviews like Ms. Lal's (herbal beverages for therapeutic purposes). Government incubators too need to have more resourceful personnel and specialised information related to concerned ministries, their bodies, functions, and provisions for entrepreneurs, so that they can direct entrepreneurs to the most relevant entities and resources for their requirements.

Women-Specific Entrepreneurial Challenges

What other challenges does Ms. Lal think women entrepreneurs face over their male counterparts?

Ms. Lal reiterates that society is patriarchal and offers more opportunities to men for both personal and professional growth. This begins during childhood itself, when male children are given more exposure to the world around them than female children. She adds that limiting learning opportunities for women restricts their growth as entrepreneurs. Learning extends far beyond formal institutions like schools and colleges; women should also be encouraged to seek constant learning opportunities through informal interactions and lived experiences. After formal education, many women in India are not given a chance to put their skills into practice or enter the formal working sector. Ms. Lal adds that women are focused, committed, and resilient, thus making them great businesspeople. Women must be made aware of the schemes, provisions, and assistance available for them. Filling this knowledge gap will help mitigate the myriad challenges they face.

Message for Other Women Entrepreneurs

What would Ms. Lal like to say to other women entrepreneurs?

If one wants to become an entrepreneur, they need to break barriers. Women must make use of the learning and skill enhancement opportunities available to them today due to easy access to the Internet. One must keep themselves updated, growth-conscious, and eager to learn. She says,

One should come out of their comfort zone.”

Ms. Amrita Sabat
Odisha

Introduction

Amrita Sabat is the Managing Director of Sabat Exports Private Limited and co-founder of the brand Utkalamrita, which promotes Odisha's handicrafts and handloom worldwide. After graduating as an engineer and working after her MBA at prestigious MNCs, Amrita decided to return to her home state and start up a business of her own. In 2015, she and her sister realised that there was no online presence of Odisha's special handicraft and handloom products on any of the leading e-commerce websites. This gap in the growing online market space pushed them to start their entrepreneurial journey and introduce the world to Odisha's unique products, such as clothing, art, painting, jewellery, handloom, and spices.

What is special about Amrita and her business?

Amrita and her sister have been felicitated time and again for their unique business journey and milestones by the state government and several organisations. Their business is helping bridge the gap between artisans in Odisha and relevant product markets. Utkalamrita has exported Odisha's unique handloom weaves and craft packages to several international destinations like USA, Dubai, Singapore, UK, Hong Kong, Fiji Islands, Canada, and more. In 2018, they became an Authorised User (AU) of the "Orissa Ikat" GI (Geographical Indication) tag and in 2022, they started the world's first Odisha Handloom GI store. GI tags help consumers identify and differentiate products with unique attributes linked to their geographical origin. Utkalamrita's website is characterised by GI information about Odisha's Sarees for the customers 'to see, read and buy.' Amrita opposes the idea of standardising handicraft products and believes that modern powerlooms should not overshadow traditional handlooms. She believes that the uniqueness of the products lies in their traditional methods, allowing artisans to showcase their creativity and hard work.

As a woman entrepreneur, she has had to face many challenges in setting up and running her business, including financial issues, insubordination of people due to her gender, deceit, and more. Braving the challenges, Amrita talked to us about her entrepreneurial journey and how she celebrates the unique weaving heritage of Odisha.

Business Financing

How has Amrita financed her business so far? Did she avail any schemes for her business? How was her experience with government schemes?

Amrita has faced several financial challenges in her way, as she and her sister navigated through numerous hardships, including COVID-19. They have largely been able to self-fund themselves since the inception of their business but have on occasions, leveraged government assistance. Under the Marketing Assistance Scheme, MSMEs can seek partial subsidies for two international fairs per year. Amrita availed of this scheme for an exhibition in China, but the reimbursement process was prolonged and did not cover the full costs. She suggests that it would be helpful if the subsidy payments under such a scheme were at par with the actual costs incurred, and also given out in advance. The Directorate of Export Promotion & Marketing (DEPM) funded their exhibition stall in Malaysia, but they had to share it with two other vendors. As a result, they could not display their products properly and attracted fewer buyers. Without allowing these limitations to discourage her, she plans to explore other government financing schemes to grow her business to the fullest.

Training and Education

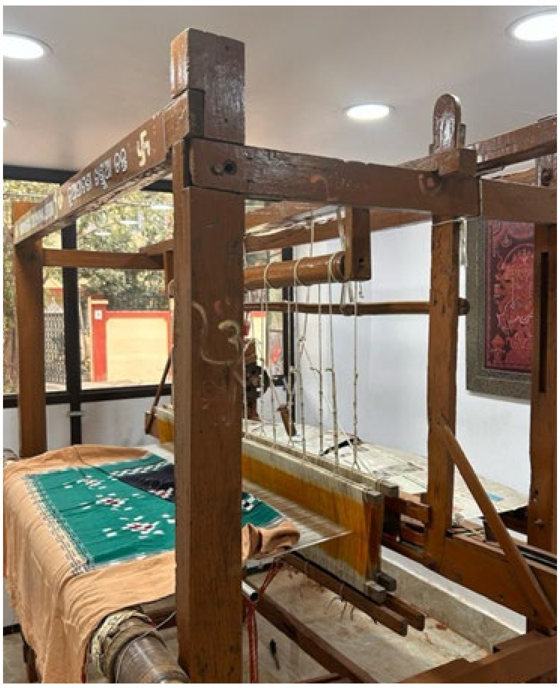
Did Amrita have any training to run her business? What kind of training does she suggest there be for assisting other women entrepreneurs?

Amrita has a background in business through her family and education and prior work experience with MNCs. However, she points out that the government should provide training and assistance not just for women entrepreneurs but everyone who decides to venture into business in the MSME sector. She suggests that there should be assistance in administrative work and formal procedures like filling out export invoices. Since these procedures are compulsory and non-negotiable, practical and business-relevant training will ensure a smoother journey for all entrepreneurs.

Accessing Markets

Over the last couple of years, how has Amrita made and maintained her market reach?

As early as the first year of the business, Amrita and her sister started foreign exhibitions for Odisha's handloom and handicraft to diversify their markets and revenue prospects. Utkalamrita has had several international exhibitions in Singapore, China, Australia, Malaysia etc., and nationally in Goa, Mumbai, Bengaluru,



Coimbatore, etc. Over time, they have continually changed their marketing strategies based on customer preferences and market trends. In 2020, Amrita revamped the business website and started social media advertisements. Due to the pandemic, the business completely shifted to the online medium. In 2023, they had to stop online advertising due to its high financial costs. Today, their sales are completely organic. Amrita believes that it is an entrepreneur's job to research their markets and customers. She has sustained and grown her market connections with the help of business knowledge, research, and keeping up with changing trends among her customer base.

Policy and Institutional Support

What has been Amrita's experience with the government and regulations? What changes does she suggest?

Amrita has an international business and is registered with the relevant government bodies. She states that women do not need hand-holding for establishing their business, but some things could definitely be made more accessible and user-friendly in terms of procedures. The government should ensure that mandatory procedures are not just easy and business-friendly but also taught to the entrepreneurs at different stages in their journey to enable better opportunities. She also strongly suggests that the government should identify genuine exporters that will make optimal use of state resources and encourage them. She highlights the lack of a centralised database for information on government support available, especially for those in rural areas. She has taken the initiative of submitting a report on the same to the DEPM.

Women-Specific Entrepreneurial Challenges

What other challenges does Amrita think women entrepreneurs face over their male counterparts?

Amrita says that one of the biggest challenges for women entrepreneurs is that they do not get their fair share of respect and recognition. She adds that this attitude of ignorance is so prevalent that now it is almost natural and innately accepted. Amrita highlights that women entrepreneurs need the support of everyone around them, including friends, family, and business personnel to run a successful business. Social norms and gender discrimination pose significant challenges for women entrepreneurs.

Message for Other Women Entrepreneurs

What would Amrita like to say to other women entrepreneurs?

Amrita asks women entrepreneurs to have the courage to act upon their dreams. She encourages women to work hard to become entrepreneurs. She believes that all of us have ideas, but only some of us work on them. When someone else has worked on the same or similar ideas, we feel deprived. To avoid this, she says,

> **"If you want to do something and achieve something then work, work hard."**

Ms. Palaniyammal
Tamil Nadu

Introduction

Ms. Palaniyammal is a micro scale entrepreneur who owns a vegetable shop in Tamil Nadu. She is an entrepreneur under the support of Rural Education and Environment Development Service (REEDS).

Ms. Palaniyammal shares the remarkable story of how she started off with limited resources, built her business from the ground up, and demonstrated remarkable tenacity. Through her unwavering determination and proactive approach, Ms. Palaniyammal has skillfully navigated through challenges such as illiteracy and a lack of access to traditional financial systems. She has meticulously committed herself to her business, allowing her to expand from selling simple bamboo baskets to operating a vegetable shop that meets the needs of her local community.

Business Financing

How has Ms. Palaniyammal financed her business so far?

Ms. Palaniyammal initially secured financial support from REED, which provided her with a funding amount of INR 45,000 (US$ 543.54). She invested this capital into her business and used a rotational strategy to ensure that her funds are continuously working for her.

As her business began to flourish, she transitioned from selling bamboo baskets to operating a vegetable shop. She has now leveraged her profits to rent a vehicle for everyday operations, enhancing her business prospects, given her physical challenges due to a broken leg. The vehicle not only facilitates transportation of her goods to people but also expands her market reach and visibility, enabling her to access a broader customer base.

Training and Education

Did Ms. Palaniyammal have any training to run her business?

Ms. Palaniyammal recalls receiving foundational training through REED, which played a crucial role in preparing her for entrepreneurship. Initially, she attended pre-departure training sessions, where she gained an understanding of fundamental business principles. Later, REED called her to Tirupur for a specialised business enterprise training, tailored to equip her with practical skills essential for starting and managing a small business.

During this training, Ms. Palaniyammal learned how to apply for loans, and was also guided on selecting viable business options based on local demand and environmental factors. Additionally, the training highlighted which types of products and plants could be easily sold daily, helping her make informed decisions about the kind of business to establish. This experience provided her with the tools and confidence to begin her entrepreneurial journey, despite having received limited formal education.

What kind of training does she suggest there be for assisting other women as entrepreneurs?

Drawing from her personal experiences, Ms. Palaniyammal highlights her struggle with literacy, which hindered her ability to maintain records of her audit reports. The lack of documentation later proved to be a major barrier while seeking loans from formal banking institutions, where such records are often prerequisites for approval.

To address these challenges, she suggests that training programs should specifically target skills in record-keeping and financial management. By equipping women with the knowledge and tools to accurately document their financial activities and business operations, these programmes can enhance their credibility and readiness to approach financial institutions for support.

Accessing Markets

Over the last couple of years, how has Ms. Palaniyammal built and maintained her market reach?

Over the years Ms. Palaniyammal strategically built her market reach by offering her products at a lower profit margin than neighbouring businesses to attract more customers. Furthermore, despite not owning a vehicle, Ms. Palaniyammal has rented a vehicle to extend her business's presence to more distant areas. This mobile strategy has enabled her to reach new markets and broaden her customer base, opening up greater opportunities and visibility for her business.

Policy and Institutional Support

What has been Ms. Palaniyammal's experience with the government and its regulations?

Ms. Palaniyammal unfortunately could not access any government schemes because of numerous challenges, largely due to her lack of literacy and the absence of guidance in navigating application processes. She is yet to register on the Udyam Registration portal, a free online initiative by the Ministry of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises, which allows MSMEs to register and gain a permanent identification number and e-certificate. This online platform offers vital benefits such as easier access to financing and formal recognition, designed to help and support micro and small businesses.

However, without assistance, Ms. Palaniyammal was unable to complete essential steps such as PAN card registration, which hindered her ability to leverage the advantages offered by Udyam and similar schemes. Her situation

highlights a crucial gap, as many micro-entrepreneurs who lack literacy or digital skills are unable to access the very programmes designed to support their development. She advocates for more inclusive systems that provide hands-on support, ensuring that entrepreneurs from all backgrounds can access the resources available to them.

What regulatory changes does she suggest?

Ms. Palaniyammal stresses the need for regulatory changes to address the discrimination faced by individuals from Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (SC/ST) when seeking loans from financial institutions. Ms. Palaniyammal takes note that she and many others who lack formal education and financial literacy are unable to navigate through business procedures, leaving them disadvantaged in securing the support and resources essential for growth.

She urges the government to simplify and streamline access to financial schemes and regulatory guidelines to better serve marginalised communities. She mentioned initiatives such as Tamil Nadu Adi Dravidar Housing and Development Corporation Limited (TAHDCO) as an example of a scheme which fostered economic advancement among SC communities through programs supported by Special Central Assistance. She highlights the need for more such initiatives, emphasising not only the need for availability but also active awareness-building of the schemes available to the community to nurture an inclusive economic landscape.

Should there be training for complying with government regulations?

Ms. Palaniyammal emphasised the need for targeted training programs to help entrepreneurs understand and navigate government regulations and access available schemes. She pointed out that individuals, especially those unable to read or write, often struggle with a lack of awareness or understanding of these government resources. Without proper guidance, they miss out on potential opportunities that could support and expand their businesses to a larger scale. For entrepreneurs like herself, acquiring this knowledge would bridge a critical gap, enabling them to benefit from government assistance programs designed to aid small businesses.

Women-Specific Entrepreneurial Challenges

What other challenges does Ms. Palaniyammal think women entrepreneurs face over their counterparts?

Ms. Palaniyammal reflects upon her challenges as a woman who navigates life independently. As a single woman supporting her grandson without the backing of extended family, she has encountered considerable obstacles in securing financial support and loans from banking institutions. Her status and education frequently lead lenders to question her loan repayment capacity, perceiving a lack of conventional security. This bias has significantly hampered her ability to secure the financing necessary to expand her business.

Furthermore, limited access to financing has prevented her from purchasing a vehicle in her name. She resorts to daily rentals to meet her business needs. This dependency on rentals not only increases her operational costs but also limits her flexibility and capacity to scale. Despite these formidable challenges, she remains steadfast, ready to confront obstacles head-on with unwavering determination.

Message for Other Women Entrepreneurs

What would Ms. Palaniyammal like to say to other women entrepreneurs?
Ms. Palaniyammal encourages women entrepreneurs to be independent and confident. From her own experiences, she speaks proudly of the challenges she has overcome and her commitment to never giving up. She urges women to stay motivated and persistent, no matter the obstacles, and to keep pushing forward with strength and determination. Her journey is a testament to the strength of persistence, and she passionately encourages women to remain motivated and resolute, never yielding to setbacks.

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Annexure -1

List of Organisations/Participants

State	Roundtable 1	Roundtable 2
Chhattisgarh	• Bastar Samajik Jan Vikas Samiti	• MSME DFO • Directorate of Industries • Regional Directorate of Skill Development & Entrepreneurship • Entrepreneurship Development Institute of India • Mahila Chamber, Chhattisgarh Chamber of Commerce and Industry • Garvit Foundation • Bastar se Bazar Tak • ITM University, Raipur • Janmitram Kalyan Samiti Raigarh • Caritas India • Jan Swasthya Sahyog (JSS) • RAVI Co-operative Raigarh • Bharat Financial Inclusion Limited
Gujarat	• SEWA Gujarat	• Office of the Development Commissioner, Ministry of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises • SEWA Bank • The Centre for Entrepreneurship Development • IIT Gandhinagar • WICCI Gujarat MSME Council • Kadi Sarva Vishwidyalaya • Women Entrepreneurship Foundation • Entrepreneurship Development Institute of India • DB Sales • Vikalp • Gujarat Chamber of Commerce & Industry • Ahmedabad District Cooperative Bank Ltd. • Directorate General of Foreign Trade • IIMA Ventures • Bank of Baroda
Maharashtra	• Chaitanya	• Directorate of Vocational Education and Training • Omkara Infratech • Maharashtra Economic Development Council • Stree Mukti Sanghatana • SNDT Women's University • Saksham Foundation

State	Roundtable 1	Roundtable 2
Odisha	• Jai Durga Mahila Samiti Radharani Coir Cluster • SR Charitable Group	• ACIC GIETU Foundation • SPANDAN • Forum for Entrepreneurship Development • Directorate of Export Promotion & Marketing • MSME DI • District Industries Centre • Utkalamrita • Sabat Exports • Odita Trust • Maharaja Bhagirath Mahindra Bahadur Foundation • Odisha Assembly of Small and Medium Enterprises • FICCI Ladies Organisation • World Trade Centre • Indian Chamber of Commerce National Women's Entrepreneurship Council • State Bank of India • Canara Bank • Centurion University of Technology and Management
Tamil Nadu	• Rights Education and Development Center	• MSME Development & Facilitation Office • NABARD • Viligro • State Bank of India • Tamil Nadu Technological Hub • WICCI • Centre for Child Rights and Development • Indian Overseas Bank • FLO-FICCI • Department of Textiles, GoI
Uttar Pradesh	• SEWA Uttar Pradesh	• Department of Industries & Commerce • Uttar Pradesh Khadi and Village Industries Board • Department of Textiles, GoI • Indian Industries Association • Indo-German Cooperation on Agricultural Market Development • Bank of India • Bikalp Herbals • Craft Artisans of India

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